FREIGHT UNIVERSITY
EDUCATE • EMPOWER • ELEVATE

DISPATCHERS | BROKERS
CARRIERS | TRUCKING COMPANY OWNERS

ONBOARDING A CARRIER

GREEN LIGHT OR RED FLAG?

A Complete Beginner's Guide to Evaluating, Understanding, and Onboarding the Right Carrier and Driver



- CHECK AUTHORITY & INSURANCE
- UNDERSTAND CSA SCORES
- REVIEW INFRACTIONS
- SCREEN DRIVERS
- IDENTIFY RED FLAGS
- MAKE A SMART ONBOARDING DECISION



FIND THE RIGHT INFORMATION

Where to go, what to look at, and how to download it.



UNDERSTAND WHAT IT MEANS

Percentages, percentiles, the 7 BASICs, and danger signs.



PROTECT YOUR BUSINESS

How bad drivers hurt your CSA, and how to fix problems.

REAL EXAMPLES | STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS | SCREENSHOTS | PRACTICAL SCENARIOS

BEGINNER FRIENDLY

Green Light or Red Flag?

Carrier & Driver Vetting for Beginners

How to vet a trucking company, understand CSA records, hire safer drivers, and protect your authority.

Michael Thomas | Freight University

Working title. Review edition. October 30, 2026.

This educational book explains a method of review. Apply current rules to the actual operation and role. It does not certify a carrier or driver, establish a real-case legal conclusion, or replace official records and qualified advice on a specific matter.

Contents

Contents 3

Begin here 4

01 | The freight doesn't move until the people are right 6

02 | Know the government sources 13

03 | Understand the seven BASICs 20

04 | Numbers you can actually understand 27

05 | Download the record and read the events 34

06 | Find patterns without inventing causes 41

07 | Approve the carrier without guessing 48

08 | Driver history: find the record, don't invent the story 55

09 | Keep a bad hire from breaking the carrier 62

10 | When the government pays attention 69

11 | Improve the record the right way 76

12 | Protect the carrier and the load 83

Case desk: four investigations 90

Final practical and knowledge check 94

Desk references 97

Answer keys and feedback 99

Glossary 109

Sources and verification ledger 111

Production and release record 114

Begin here

Begin here

You do not need a safety department vocabulary to start. You need a careful sequence of questions. Who is the carrier? What does the record actually prove? What is missing? Who may lawfully obtain the next record? What decision can a responsible person make from the evidence?

How to use this book

Read the 12 chapters in order. Each chapter contains three short lessons and a field lab. Try the questions before opening the answer section. Use the companion fillable workbook and fictional CSV files to practice. The book adapts the supplied 36-lesson course plan into shorter reading lessons; it does not claim 8-14 minutes of narration per lesson. Read-time estimates in the manifest use actual word counts. No audio was generated.

Choose your role

Brokers review the carrier, applicable authority, coverage, identity, public safety history, and shipment suitability. Dispatchers support the carrier within a defined authorized role. Carrier owners and safety managers perform applicable driver-qualification and employment-screening duties. Equipment ownership alone does not establish the responsible operating carrier.

Respect the record boundary

Public company records are not private driver reports. Do not use this book to obtain another company's credentials, request protected records without a lawful role, or share driver files indiscriminately. The practice pack contains no real driver records and no real USDOT/MC numbers. Its names, dates, companies, and events are fictional.

What the decision labels mean

Green Light, Hold & Verify, and Stop are Freight University teaching labels. They are not FMCSA ratings, official scores, or guarantees. Always identify whether a stop comes from an applicable legal prohibition, a required qualification gate, or a company transaction control.

The evidence circle

See the record. Understand what it proves. Identify what is missing. Ask a fair question. Make a documented human decision. Monitor again. Use this circle in every chapter. The goal is to protect people, freight, and legitimate small carriers through accurate decisions.

Edition and source limits

Prepared October 30, 2026 for U.S. property-freight beginners. Core official sources were checked during this build; the source ledger distinguishes checked material from supplied references that still need revalidation. The seven-BASIC baseline remains separate from announced future SMS changes. Authenticated screens, report purchases, live private queries, and complete public-site download flows were not tested. The PSP page returned an offline message. Use the official links and recheck changed rules and screens before operational use or release.

MT and LFS AOS disclosures

Every MT exercise is a fictional demonstration. Publicly described application/file tracking and handoff-reported carrier lookup are distinguished from independently tested production behavior. SMS ingestion, private-report interpretation, and continuous CSA monitoring are proposed or unverified here. Official providers still handle MVR and Clearinghouse checks. No software approval replaces the responsible human's duties.

About this edition

This is a complete reading and practice edition for founder review, not a published course or a claim that the handoff's full production release gates are complete. It includes 20 original instructional diagrams and an original typeset cover. The 55 photographic assets and 20 genuine-screen captures remain individually documented production briefs. No invented government screenshots appear. The supplied teaching samples guide the voice; no personal stories or quotations have been invented for Michael Thomas. The internal teaching corpus was not queried during this build.

01 Who may see what?

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Record	Public reviewer	Authorized role
SAFER / public SMS	Public company data	Public company data
Private SMS percentile	Not publicly displayed	Carrier: its own results
PSP	No routine broker access	Prospective employer + consent; driver own
State MVR	Not a public FMCSA lookup	Lawful state/provider process
Clearinghouse	Protected	Covered employer + required consent
Employment inquiry	No automatic entitlement	Hiring carrier: applicable inquiry

Access depends on role, lawful purpose, and consent. A dispatcher needs actual authorization.

Figure 01. Read access by role, not by curiosity.

01 | The freight doesn't move until the people are right

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

01.01 | Whose truck, whose authority, whose risk?

You're about to book a truck. The person on the phone gives you a familiar business name. The packet has a different legal name, and the tractor belongs to somebody else. Which company are you actually hiring?

A motor carrier is the business responsible for operating the commercial vehicle. A broker arranges transportation by a motor carrier. A dispatcher may help a carrier find and manage work within the dispatcher's authorized role. The driver operates the vehicle. An owner-operator owns equipment and may operate either under their own carrier authority or under another carrier's authority. Equipment ownership alone doesn't answer who is responsible for the move.

A USDOT number identifies a registered entity in federal motor-carrier records. An MC docket number relates to operating-authority records. Don't paste an unlabeled number into the first search box and assume the result is correct. Confirm which kind of number you received. For-hire interstate transportation can require operating authority appropriate to the operation; not every operation has the same authority requirements. A broker's authority doesn't turn that broker into a motor carrier.

In our fictional Bayou case, a packet says "Bayou Freight." The public identity evidence in the exercise identifies a different legal entity from the payment instructions. That mismatch doesn't prove a crime. It does mean your safety review might be about the wrong business. Stop the tender while you establish the legal carrier, independently confirm its contact, and reconcile the documents. A convincing voice doesn't repair an identity mismatch.

Start W01 with the legal name, number type, source, and lookup time. Then write the role of the person doing each check. Public company records are available to a broker. Protected driver records require a lawful purpose, proper role, and any required consent. The hiring carrier normally owns driver qualification duties. A dispatcher's access must come from a real authorized role, not from knowing a password.



02 Authority, insurance, and safety

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Authority	Insurance	Safety
Permission for the applicable operation	Filings plus verified load coverage	Recorded events and fitness findings
Check type, status, and effective dates	Verify entity, dates, limits, exclusions	Read patterns, dates, and missing data

Verifying one does not prove the other two.

Instructional figure 02. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Assuming the owner of the tractor is always the operating motor carrier.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to separate the packet’s legal name, trade name, number type, and payee into four fields. Carrier lookup is described in the supplied project handoff; its current interface wasn't tested for this book. Resolve ambiguity through official records before using any result.

Try it

Draw four boxes for broker, operating carrier, equipment owner, and driver. Put Bayou’s conflicting names beside the relevant boxes. Circle what you still cannot establish.

Think it through

If the business name were removed from the packet, what evidence would still connect the truck to the carrier?

Check your understanding

1. What does a USDOT number identify?

2. Does a broker’s carrier packet authorize a private driver query?

Take this with you

Identify the operating carrier before evaluating its record.

Sources: F08, F09, F15. See source ledger for verification status.

01.02 | Why an active carrier can still be a poor choice

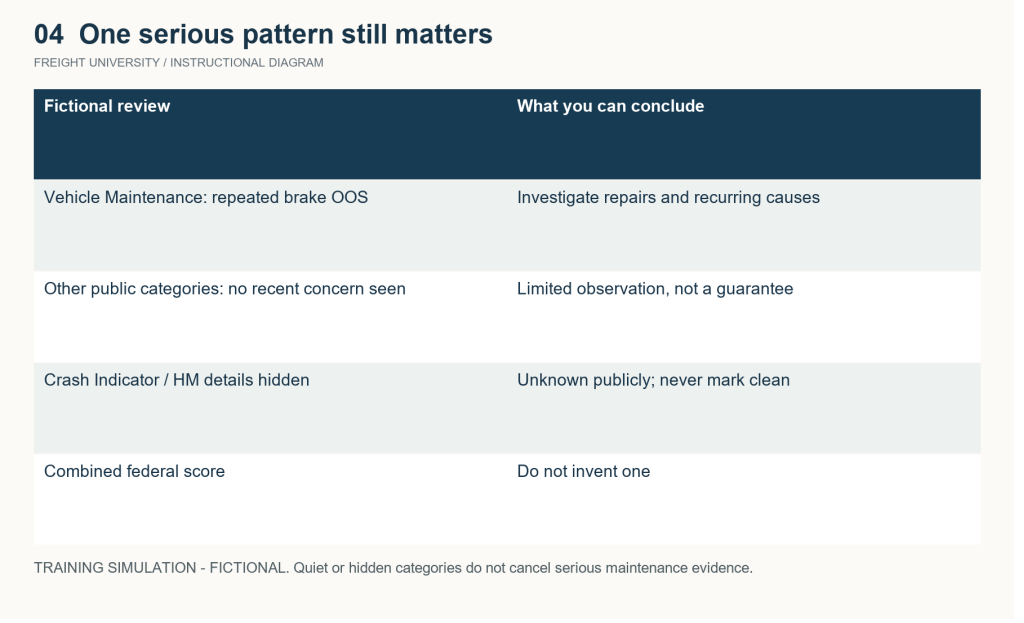
The screen says “active.” Can you put the load on the truck? You have answered one question, and several others are still open.

Registration, operating authority, insurance, and safety describe different things. Registration identifies the entity and its reported operation. Authority addresses permission for an applicable transportation activity. An insurance filing is a regulatory record; the actual policy must still fit the load. Safety history describes recorded events and, where assigned, a federal safety rating. None of these records supplies a universal guarantee.

Imagine Pine Ridge Freight, our fictional four-truck carrier. Assume the classroom packet shows the appropriate authority in effect. Eight vehicle inspections include two vehicle out-of-service inspections. Out of service means the affected vehicle couldn't continue operating until the conditions for return to service were met. The authority entry doesn't explain whether the brakes were repaired. The inspection record doesn't tell you whether a particular shipment is covered by the insurance policy.

Now consider Cedar Valley, a fictional new one-truck operator with no roadside vehicle inspections in the sample. An empty history isn't proof of poor operation. It also isn't proof of good operation. You need evidence of readiness: the correct legal status, suitable equipment, carrier qualification controls, required coverage, and a credible maintenance process. A new business deserves a fair examination, not automatic suspicion or automatic approval.

“Not Rated” or “None” means no federal safety rating has been assigned. It doesn't mean Satisfactory. Even a Satisfactory rating doesn't promise that every current truck and driver is ready today. Read the rating’s context and date, then examine current facts. A stale document can be accurate about last month and useless for a changed situation today.



04 One serious pattern still matters

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Fictional review	What you can conclude
Vehicle Maintenance: repeated brake OOS	Investigate repairs and recurring causes
Other public categories: no recent concern seen	Limited observation, not a guarantee
Crash Indicator / HM details hidden	Unknown publicly; never mark clean
Combined federal score	Do not invent one

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Quiet or hidden categories do not cancel serious maintenance evidence.

Instructional figure 04. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating an active registration label as a complete carrier approval.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Give MT five headings: identity, authority, coverage, safety evidence, and unknowns. Ask it to keep unresolved items visible. Automatic public SMS analysis is a proposed workflow, not a capability verified by this book.

Try it

Write five questions still unanswered by Pine Ridge's active-authority entry. Include one question about the specific load and one about the affected equipment.

Think it through

Which unanswered question could change your decision before pickup?

Check your understanding

1. Does Not Rated mean Satisfactory?

2. Do zero recorded inspections prove Cedar Valley is safe?

Take this with you

An active status starts the review; it doesn't finish it.

Sources: F01, F08, F09. See source ledger for verification status.

01.03 | Green, hold, and stop

You need a decision you can explain to somebody who wasn't in the room. “Looks fine” isn't enough. This book uses three local decision labels: Green Light, Hold & Verify, and Stop. They are Freight University teaching labels, not federal ratings.

Green Light means the required legal and company-policy checks have been satisfied, material concerns have been resolved, and the authorized person may approve the defined move or assignment. It doesn't mean future harm is impossible. Hold & Verify means something material remains unresolved: missing evidence, stale information, repeat defects, or an unexplained discrepancy. Name the evidence needed to release the hold.

Stop means don't proceed with the defined transaction or assignment. An effective applicable out-of-service prohibition is a legal stop. A confirmed disqualified driver cannot be assigned work for which that driver is disqualified. Required pre-service screening that remains incomplete blocks covered safety-sensitive work. A material identity mismatch can stop a transaction under company controls without being a federal prohibition. Write which kind of stop you mean.

Use Pine Ridge to practice precision. Repeat historical brake defects justify a hold while repairs and controls are examined. If the proposed tractor is still subject to an unresolved vehicle OOS condition, don't dispatch that tractor. That doesn't establish that every other vehicle is prohibited forever. Conversely, replacing the tractor doesn't resolve a company-wide operating prohibition. Match the decision to its actual scope.

For Bayou, write “Stop this tender until the legal carrier and payee are reconciled.” Don't write “FMCSA shut Bayou down” when the exercise contains no such order. For Robert Miller, write “Qualification pending; no covered safety-sensitive assignment until required gates are complete.” Don't write “Unsafe because he changed jobs.” Good decisions describe the evidence and what happens next.

12 Green Light / Hold & Verify / Stop

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Decision	Meaning
Green Light	Required checks satisfied; authorized human approval
Hold & Verify	Material uncertainty or concern needs evidence
Stop	Do not proceed with defined move or assignment
Always specify scope	Legal prohibition, qualification gate, or company control

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY DECISION AID - NOT AN FMCSA STATUS OR CERTIFICATION.

Instructional figure 12. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Using red as a public accusation or treating green as a government certification.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to draft the reason, scope, unresolved evidence, reviewer, and next-review date. Proposed decision support must leave approval with the responsible person.

Try it

Sort these findings: current applicable OOS order; missing repair proof; fully verified required checks; inconsistent payee; no assigned rating; pending required full Clearinghouse query. State the scope of every stop or hold.

Think it through

What evidence would make you change your mind?

Check your understanding

1. Are these colors FMCSA ratings?

2. Is a historical OOS event always a current operating ban?

Take this with you

State the decision, its scope, and the evidence needed next.

Sources: F01, F15. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 01 | Roles and decisions

Use: W01, W06

Use Bayou and Travis. Identify the operating carrier, equipment owner, broker, and authorized driver-screening role. Sort the six findings in 01.03.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

02 | Know the government sources

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

02.01 | SAFER: your first public carrier check

Before you read percentages, make sure you're reading the right company. SAFER's Company Snapshot is a public starting point for identity, reported operations, inspection totals, crashes, and displayed federal safety rating. It isn't a complete driver file or a load-specific approval.

Open https://safer.fmcsa.dot.gov/CompanySnapshot.aspx. Choose the USDOT search option, enter the carrier's confirmed USDOT number, and submit the search. Read the returned legal name and physical address before copying anything else. Compare the identity with the packet. If the match is uncertain, pause; don't choose the closest-looking name. The training case labels in this book are not real USDOT numbers and must not be entered as such.

Record the lookup time, displayed record dates, USDOT status, operating-authority summary if shown, power units, drivers, and MCS-150 filing date. MCS-150 is the carrier identification report used for registration information. Reported fleet figures may lag operational changes. An older filing deserves follow-up; it doesn't prove dishonesty.

Go to the inspection and crash section. Copy vehicle inspection totals and vehicle OOS counts together. Copy driver totals and driver OOS counts separately. Retain the time window and any national-average date displayed. Then record the safety rating exactly, including None if that is what appears. Don't replace an empty field with "passed." Use W01 for identity and W02 for the numeric interpretation.

In the Pine Ridge simulation, your worksheet should preserve eight vehicle inspections and ten driver inspections as two different denominators. If you copy eight into both rows, the later arithmetic will be wrong even if your calculator works perfectly. A careful reviewer can trace each number to the correct source field. That trace is more valuable than a colorful summary.

05 Use the correct denominator

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Calculation	Result
2 vehicle OOS / 8 vehicle inspections x 100	25% vehicle OOS rate
1 driver OOS / 10 driver inspections x 100	10% driver OOS rate
Vehicle count is not driver count	Keep the two denominators separate
Neither result is an SMS percentile	No private rank calculated

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Count unique eligible inspections, not violation rows.

Instructional figure 05. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Copying a national comparison percentage without its date or comparing unlike inspection types.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to format your manually transcribed public facts with their dates and source labels. Recheck each number against the source; automatic SAFER safety extraction wasn't verified here.

Try it

Complete W01 and W02 using the fictional Pine Ridge packet. On a live public page, identify the relevant fields without conducting a real carrier approval.

Think it through

Which field tells you the age of the underlying information rather than when you opened the page?

Check your understanding

1. Is SAFER a violation-by-violation lifetime report?

2. What should you verify before copying inspection counts?

Take this with you

Copy identity and dates with the numbers.

Sources: F08, F12. See source ledger for verification status.

02.02 | Licensing & Insurance: permission to haul

A company can have a USDOT record without holding the authority required for the move you're considering. Licensing & Insurance, usually called L&I, helps answer the separate authority and federal-filing questions.

Open https://li-public.fmcsa.dot.gov/. Follow Carrier Search and search with the correct number type. Complete any required human verification yourself; don't bypass it. Open the matching result's HTML details, then review Authority Status and Authority History where available. These steps follow FMCSA's published lookup guidance. If the site changes its labels, use that guidance and record the actual path you see rather than guessing at a hidden control.

Read the authority type, current status, and relevant effective dates. A broker-only authority doesn't authorize that entity to operate as the motor carrier for your shipment. An application isn't the same thing as effective authority. A historical grant isn't proof that authority remains in effect. Save the exact facts rather than shortening every result to "active."

Next, examine required insurance filings and the dates shown. A certificate of insurance, or COI, is evidence to verify; it isn't the entire insurance contract. Confirm appropriate coverage, limits, dates, exclusions, and load suitability through the insurer or authorized insurance representative under your process. Verify contact information independently. This book doesn't prescribe one coverage amount for every commodity or operation.

Suppose Bayou sends a certificate with the expected trade name, while the authority record identifies another legal entity. Don't solve the mismatch by assuming all similar names belong to the same insured company. Ask for clarification through independently established contacts. Record which entity the insurer confirms, what was confirmed, and what remains unanswered. Authority and coverage must connect to the carrier actually doing the work.



02 Authority, insurance, and safety

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Authority	Insurance	Safety
Permission for the applicable operation	Filings plus verified load coverage	Recorded events and fitness findings
Check type, status, and effective dates	Verify entity, dates, limits, exclusions	Read patterns, dates, and missing data

Verifying one does not prove the other two.

Instructional figure 02. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Accepting a filing or certificate as a guarantee that every cargo loss will be covered.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to separate “official filing observed” from “coverage confirmed with insurer.” The handoff describes authority/filing lookup; current fields and behavior need interface verification.

Try it

Write an L&I verification note with identity, authority type, status, effective dates, filing evidence, and one unresolved coverage question.

Think it through

If a certificate and the official identity disagree, whom would you contact independently?

Check your understanding

1. Is an authority application the same as granted effective authority?

2. Can a broker-only entity be treated as the hauling carrier?

Take this with you

Connect authority and coverage to the exact carrier and move.

Sources: F09, F10. See source ledger for verification status.

02.03 | SMS, Portal, and the Company Safety Profile

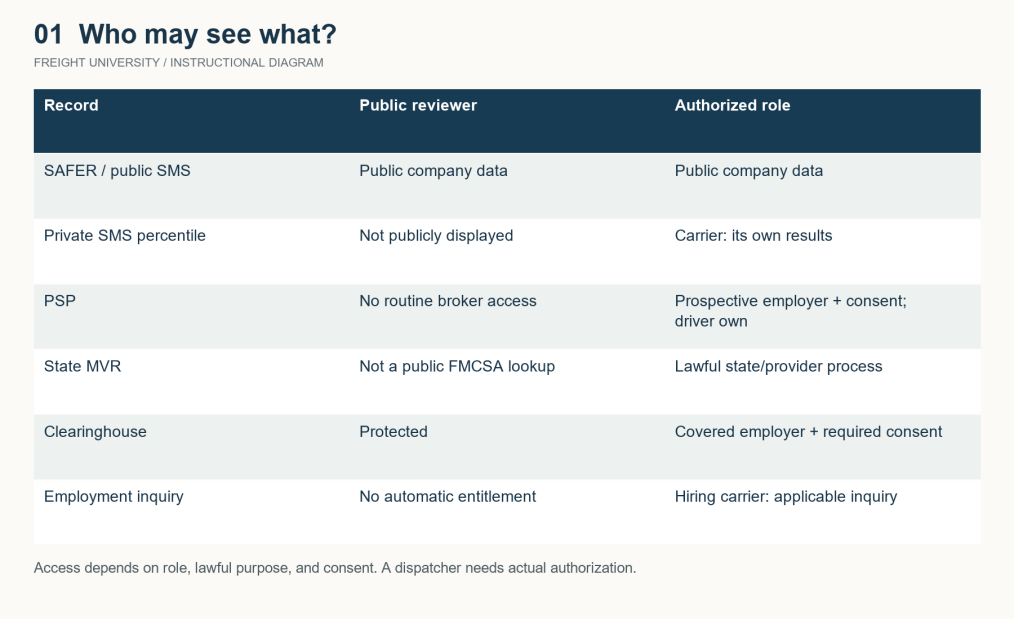
Different doors lead to different records. The public Safety Measurement System, or SMS, helps you examine available carrier safety events and measures. An authorized carrier's own login reveals additional information. The FMCSA Portal supplies account-restricted functions. A Company Safety Profile, or CSP, is a separate report drawn from agency records.

For public SMS, open https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/ and search the confirmed USDOT number. Match the identity again. Public property-carrier results do not display BASIC percentiles or intervention-prioritization indicators; Crash Indicator and Hazardous Materials Compliance BASIC details are hidden. Some crash summary data remains public. A hidden category is not a clean category.

For your own authorized carrier account, use the official login. Never borrow another company's credentials. If a carrier voluntarily shares a private result for an appropriate purpose, label it carrier-provided private evidence. That isn't the same as independently retrieving a public percentile. Preserve confidentiality and record authenticity limitations.

FMCSA's current CSP instructions say authorized company officials sign into https://portal.fmcsa.dot.gov/, choose Reports, select a date range and report information, and submit the request. After confirmation, choose Check Request Availability. Once available, use Download PDF or Download XML. This is a documented agency procedure, not an authenticated workflow tested for this book. Other persons are directed to FMCSA's FOIA process; don't use obsolete paid-CSP request instructions.

Think about the question before choosing the source. "What is the displayed rating?" points to SAFER. "What authority is in effect?" points to L&I. "Which roadside events support the available safety data?" points to SMS. "What does the applicant's state license record show?" requires an authorized state MVR process. No single door answers every question.



01 Who may see what?

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Record	Public reviewer	Authorized role
SAFER / public SMS	Public company data	Public company data
Private SMS percentile	Not publicly displayed	Carrier: its own results
PSP	No routine broker access	Prospective employer + consent; driver own
State MVR	Not a public FMCSA lookup	Lawful state/provider process
Clearinghouse	Protected	Covered employer + required consent
Employment inquiry	No automatic entitlement	Hiring carrier: applicable inquiry

Access depends on role, lawful purpose, and consent. A dispatcher needs actual authorization.

Instructional figure 01. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Describing a public SMS export as every infraction or private record the government has.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to create a source-routing checklist. Private account access and automatic CSP retrieval are not established features in this book.

Try it

Route these questions: legal name, authority status, public inspection detail, own private percentile, CSP, applicant license status, applicant employment dates, drug/alcohol query status, data correction, crash preventability review.

Think it through

Which questions require a permission check before a record search?

Check your understanding

1. Who can obtain a CSP directly through the carrier Portal process?

2. Is a carrier-shared percentile publicly verified?

Take this with you

Choose the record that answers your question and respect its access rules.

Sources: F01, F02, F11, F12. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 02 | Two public sources

Use: W01, W02

Locate the identity fields on SAFER and the authority/filing route in L&I. Use Pine Ridge numbers for your worksheet, not a real carrier judgment.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

03 | Understand the seven BASICs

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

03.01 | Seven separate drawers

People say “CSA score” as though there were one number for the whole company. That shortcut can hide the exact problem you need to see. Compliance, Safety, Accountability, or CSA, is the federal safety program. SMS is the measurement system. BASIC means Behavior Analysis and Safety Improvement Category.

The current baseline checked for this edition uses seven categories: Unsafe Driving; Crash Indicator; Hours-of-Service Compliance; Vehicle Maintenance; Controlled Substances/Alcohol; Hazardous Materials Compliance; and Driver Fitness. Keep the labels distinct. A maintenance pattern doesn't disappear because other categories show few publicly visible events.

The SMS page checked October 30, 2026 showed data through September 25, 2026 and a website update of October 5, 2026. The agency’s preview page said the approved updated methodology was still forthcoming. This book therefore teaches the current seven-BASIC structure, not a mixture of current and future category names. Recheck that distinction before teaching from a later edition.

Use W03 as seven separate evidence drawers. For each category, record what is visible, what is unavailable, the dates, and the next fair question. For a public property-carrier review, don't fill the private percentile column with an estimate. Mark it not publicly displayed. Mark the two hidden BASIC detail areas as hidden, even if public crash counts exist elsewhere.

Pine Ridge illustrates the point. Repeat brake problems matter even if you don't see recent speeding or log violations. You haven't established six perfect categories, and you can't average broken brakes away. Your job is to identify the maintenance evidence, ask what changed, and evaluate whether the affected equipment and the carrier’s process are ready for the proposed work.

03 The seven BASICs

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Category	Public property-carrier view
Unsafe Driving	Measure / available supporting data
Crash Indicator	BASIC details hidden
Hours-of-Service Compliance	Measure / available supporting data
Vehicle Maintenance	Measure / available supporting data
Controlled Substances/Alcohol	Measure / available supporting data
Hazardous Materials Compliance	BASIC details hidden
Driver Fitness	Measure / available supporting data

Property-carrier percentiles and prioritization indicators are not publicly displayed.

Instructional figure 03. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Adding category observations into a made-up federal overall score.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT for a seven-row summary with separate “observed,” “not available,” and “follow-up” fields. The integrated SMS analyzer is proposed and not independently verified as live.

Try it

Write all seven category names from memory, then check them. Mark which BASIC details are hidden in a public property-carrier review.

Think it through

How could an empty box mislead somebody reading your summary?

Check your understanding

1. Is CSA one official carrier score?

2. Can six quiet categories cancel repeated brake defects?

Take this with you

Review each category without inventing a combined verdict.

Sources: F01, F02, F03, F05. See source ledger for verification status.

03.02 | Unsafe Driving, HOS, and Driver Fitness

A speeding entry, a log violation, and a missing endorsement aren't interchangeable. All deserve attention, but they raise different questions about what happened and what must change.

Unsafe Driving includes behaviors such as speeding, following too closely, improper lane use, cellphone violations, and seat-belt violations. Hours-of-Service, or HOS, concerns applicable driving and duty limits and records. An electronic logging device, or ELD, records certain driving and duty information; its presence doesn't prove the logs are accurate or the schedule is lawful. Driver Fitness concerns qualifications such as the required license, endorsements, and physical qualification. It isn't a measure of how athletic a person is.

Blue Ridge’s fictional new driver has an April following-too-close event and a June speeding event. Those records support a question about repeat driving behavior. They don't establish that a dispatcher ordered the driver to speed. Ask what the carrier reviewed, whether the driver was coached, what routes and appointment expectations applied, and whether later observations show a change. Separate a possible explanation from a proven cause.

For a log problem, examine the actual description and record. Was the concern missing documentation, inaccurate entries, or driving beyond an applicable limit? The corrective action should fit the finding. Training somebody to operate an ELD menu won't solve a dispatch plan that requires impossible travel time. Likewise, changing appointments won't correct a license endorsement the driver never held.

When an entry suggests a current qualification problem, the authorized carrier must resolve eligibility before assigning affected work. A broker can ask the carrier to confirm that it has assigned a properly qualified driver without demanding the driver’s entire private file. Keep the question relevant to the role and the load.

03 The seven BASICs

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Category	Public property-carrier view
Unsafe Driving	Measure / available supporting data
Crash Indicator	BASIC details hidden
Hours-of-Service Compliance	Measure / available supporting data
Vehicle Maintenance	Measure / available supporting data
Controlled Substances/Alcohol	Measure / available supporting data
Hazardous Materials Compliance	BASIC details hidden
Driver Fitness	Measure / available supporting data

Property-carrier percentiles and prioritization indicators are not publicly displayed.

Instructional figure 03. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Claiming every HOS violation proves coercion or every license issue proves intentional deception.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to group supplied fictional events by category and draft neutral follow-up questions. Proposed analysis must not infer motive or access private qualifications without authorization.

Try it

Classify following too close, a missing required endorsement, and a false-log finding. For each, write one record to inspect and one question to ask.

Think it through

Would your proposed corrective action address the actual finding?

Check your understanding

1. Does Driver Fitness mean physical exercise?

2. Does a log violation alone prove dispatch coercion?

Take this with you

Different findings require different evidence and corrective actions.

Sources: F02, F15. See source ledger for verification status.

03.03 | Equipment, substances, hazardous materials, and crashes

An inspection says the brakes were defective. What does that prove? It proves the recorded finding, subject to verification and any valid correction. It doesn't tell you, by itself, why the defect existed or whether the whole maintenance department was careless.

Vehicle Maintenance covers equipment-related issues such as brakes, tires, lamps, steering, suspension, and applicable securement or inspection requirements. Read the actual violation description. A mechanic’s repair record, unit identifier, completion date, and release evidence help connect a response to the affected equipment. A generic invoice saying “service” may not establish that the cited defect was corrected.

Controlled Substances/Alcohol concerns applicable roadside violations and disqualifying conduct. A public entry isn't a complete private testing history. Don't infer that the employer had no testing program from a single entry. The authorized carrier must investigate the relevant duties and current eligibility through proper channels. Hazardous Materials Compliance concerns obligations such as shipping papers, placards, and packaging when the operation involves regulated hazardous materials. Evaluate the operation actually proposed.

Crash Indicator is another separate category. A reportable crash indicates involvement, not an automatic finding of fault. Golden Plains, a fictional carrier, has a crash in which the supplied narrative says its truck was struck while legally stopped. The police report and other evidence matter. The narrative alone isn't an agency preventability determination.

For public property-carrier users, Crash Indicator and HM Compliance BASIC details are hidden. That doesn't mean every fact about a crash is hidden, and it doesn't mean there were no HM issues. Write exactly what source you can see. If the information is unavailable, explain the limit instead of quietly leaving a reassuring blank.

18 Crash involvement and preventability

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Stage	Effect
Crash reported	Involvement does not establish fault
Eligible CPDP request	Evidence and required police report submitted
Not Preventable determination	Excluded from Crash Indicator calculation
Record still listed	PSP notation; no automatic safety-rating change

No favorable outcome is promised. Check current eligibility and the actual determination.

Instructional figure 18. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating a crash count as a fault count or an unavailable HM category as zero violations.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to label observations, possible causes, and verified causes separately. Private testing and hidden BASIC interpretation are not publicly available automated checks.

Try it

For a brake finding, a public substance-related entry, and Golden Plains' crash, write what the evidence proves and one thing it doesn't prove.

Think it through

What evidence would connect a repair invoice to the exact cited unit?

Check your understanding

1. Does a reported crash establish the carrier caused it?

2. Can a public BASIC reveal a complete private drug-test history?

Take this with you

Describe the observed event before discussing its possible cause.

Sources: F01, F02, F20. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 03 | Seven evidence drawers

Use: W03

Classify speeding, false logs, brakes, missing endorsement, applicable roadside alcohol conduct, placarding, and a reportable crash. Mark public limits.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

04 | Numbers you can actually understand

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

04.01 | What percentages mean

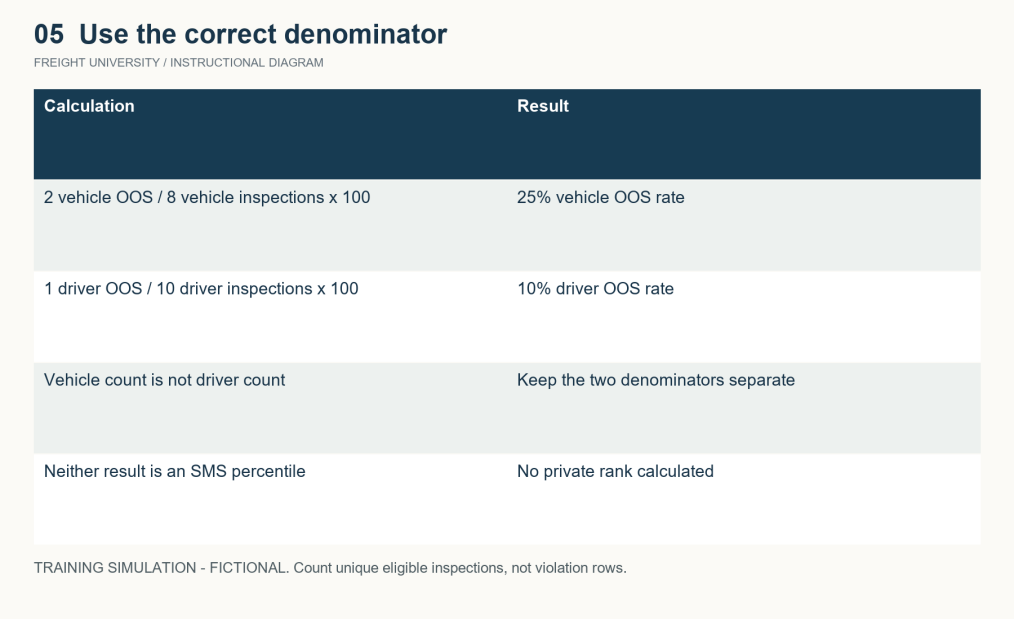
Two of Pine Ridge's eight eligible vehicle inspections resulted in vehicle OOS. Divide two by eight, then multiply by 100. The result is 25%. The numerator is the OOS inspection count. The denominator is the eligible vehicle inspection count. Both numbers refer to the same period and type of inspection.

Now calculate the driver rate. One of ten eligible driver inspections resulted in driver OOS: 1 / 10 x 100 = 10%. Don't divide that one driver event by the eight vehicle inspections. The denominator must match the question. Fleet size isn't the denominator for either calculation. Four tractors doesn't turn two OOS inspections into a 50% vehicle inspection rate.

An inspection can contain several violation rows. If one inspection lists a brake defect and a tire defect, those two rows still belong to one inspection. To count OOS inspections, first identify distinct inspection IDs and the applicable OOS outcome. A violation-only file may omit clean inspections, so it may not supply the full denominator. Obtain the complete eligible inspection totals before calculating a rate.

What about Cedar Valley's zero OOS events and zero inspections? Zero divided by zero is undefined. It isn't a measured 0% failure rate. Preserve the source's displayed wording, but explain that there were no observations for this classroom calculation. By comparison, zero OOS out of twenty eligible inspections is a measured 0% OOS rate for that sample. It still doesn't prove there were zero violations.

Small samples move sharply. One OOS inspection out of two is 50%; one additional inspection with no OOS changes the fraction to one out of three, about 33.3%. The truck didn't magically become one-third safer. You changed the sample. Compare dates, inspection types, selection, and sample sizes before interpreting differences or national averages.



05 Use the correct denominator

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Calculation	Result
2 vehicle OOS / 8 vehicle inspections x 100	25% vehicle OOS rate
1 driver OOS / 10 driver inspections x 100	10% driver OOS rate
Vehicle count is not driver count	Keep the two denominators separate
Neither result is an SMS percentile	No private rank calculated

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Count unique eligible inspections, not violation rows.

Instructional figure 05. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Counting violation rows as inspections or calling 0/0 a clean record.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to show numerator, denominator, period, and arithmetic. Check the source counts yourself; the proposed analyzer must not manufacture missing clean inspections.

Try it

Calculate 2/8, 1/10, 0/20, and 0/0. Label every answer with its inspection type and explain why the last answer isn't a percentage.

Think it through

Could your spreadsheet contain every violation but still lack the denominator?

Check your understanding

1. What is Pine Ridge’s vehicle OOS rate?

2. Is zero driver OOS proof of zero unsafe-driving violations?

Take this with you

Name the numerator and denominator before trusting a percentage.

Sources: F08. See source ledger for verification status.

04.02 | What a percentile means

A percentage describes a fraction. A percentile describes relative position in a comparison group. An SMS measure is a category-specific value calculated using the applicable methodology. These are three different ideas, even when somebody casually calls all of them a score.

An illustrative 72nd percentile describes comparatively poorer performance than roughly 72% of the relevant comparison group. It doesn't mean 72% of drivers are unsafe, 72% of inspections failed, or the next trip has a 72% crash probability. Actual grouping, ties, eligibility, and rounding affect interpretation. Higher SMS percentiles generally indicate poorer relative performance.

You can't take Pine Ridge's 25% vehicle OOS rate and announce its Vehicle Maintenance percentile. A real percentile depends on the applicable measure, eligibility, comparison population, and snapshot. Public property-carrier percentiles aren't displayed. The absence of a publicly visible percentile isn't evidence that FMCSA forgot to rank the carrier or that the carrier has no concerns.

Under the current general-carrier threshold structure, Unsafe Driving, Crash Indicator, and HOS use 65; Vehicle Maintenance, Controlled Substances/Alcohol, and Driver Fitness use 80; HM Compliance uses 80. Placardable-HM and passenger criteria have different thresholds for several categories. The reference table later in the book preserves all three columns. Confirm the applicable criteria on the current official page.

A threshold is an intervention-prioritization signal. It isn't automatic cancellation of authority. Nor does an 80 threshold mean brakes or driver qualifications matter less than a category with 65. Read any actual notice or prohibition separately. Your company can require additional review without misrepresenting that policy as a federal ban.

06 Rate, measure, and percentile

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Number	Meaning
OOS rate	Eligible OOS inspections / eligible inspections
SMS measure	Category value under the applicable methodology
SMS percentile	Relative position in the relevant comparison group
Illustrative 72nd percentile	Comparative performance, not 72% crash probability

Property-carrier percentiles are private; a public OOS rate cannot substitute for them.

Instructional figure 06. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Turning a percentile into a crash probability or a public OOS rate into a private rank.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to identify which of three supplied numbers is a rate, measure, or percentile. It must decline to invent a private rank from public rows.

Try it

Mark true or false: 25% OOS equals 25th percentile; 72nd percentile is a comparison; public property percentiles are visible; 65 automatically ends authority; category thresholds differ; some carriers lack enough qualifying data for a percentile.

Think it through

Would the same number mean the same thing in a different column?

Check your understanding

1. What information is needed beyond a few violations to determine a real percentile?

2. Does crossing a threshold automatically prohibit operation?

Take this with you

Read the label on the number before interpreting it.

Sources: F02, F03, F06, F07. See source ledger for verification status.

04.03 | Severity, recency, and sample size

A broken lamp and a serious brake defect shouldn't be treated as identical just because each occupies one row. SMS uses category-specific methods that account for factors such as severity, age, and exposure. The details matter, and different BASICs don't all use the same denominator.

The current carrier SMS analysis uses a rolling 24-month window. A rolling window moves forward with time. Recent events can carry different influence from older events, and older events eventually move outside the relevant window. Don't confuse this carrier window with PSP's separate driver-report windows.

Suppose a one-truck carrier has one recent OOS inspection and very little other inspection history. Another carrier has one OOS inspection among one hundred eligible inspections in the same example period. The first sample is thin; the second is broader. Neither comparison supplies an exact SMS percentile. Exposure and peer grouping must be handled under the actual category methodology, not guessed from fleet size.

For everyday review, make a dated event list. Identify repeated themes, serious findings, affected units, and verified responses. Keep clean inspection totals where available. Clean inspections may affect relevant inspection-based measures or rates, but don't promise that every clean inspection changes every BASIC in the same way. A month with no new rows may reflect no new inspections, delayed reporting, or genuinely uneventful operations.

Blue Ridge's April and June driving findings followed by an August equipment OOS deserve separate questions. The dates show a sequence; they don't prove a single cause. If the driver leaves in September, the valid historical carrier events don't vanish. Operational improvement means changing the conditions that produced the events and checking what happens next. It doesn't mean waiting for a calendar to erase the problem.

07 Sparse data needs care

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

OOS / inspections	Simple rate	Interpretation
0 / 0	Undefined	No observations
1 / 2	50%	Very small sample
2 / 8	25%	Small sample
20 / 100	20%	Broader sample, still limited

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Rates alone do not establish a carrier safety verdict.

Instructional figure 07. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Promising a fixed percentile decrease or insurance discount after a set number of clean days.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT for a dated trend narrative with sample-size limits. Exact SMS calculation and automatic monitoring remain proposed; no fictional percentile should be generated.

Try it

Compare one OOS in two inspections with twenty OOS in one hundred. Calculate the simple rates, then list what those rates cannot tell you.

Think it through

Are you seeing safer operation, more observation, or merely a different time window?

Check your understanding

1. Do all BASICs use the same exposure denominator?

2. Does a driver leaving remove valid earlier carrier events?

Take this with you

Read the dates and the sample before announcing a trend.

Sources: F02, F03, F04. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 04 | Use the denominator

Use: W02

Calculate Pine Ridge 2/8 and 1/10; Cedar Valley 0/0; Delta 0/20. Explain why none supplies a private percentile.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

05 | Download the record and read the events

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

05.01 | From the snapshot to the correct SMS page

You found the right company on SAFER. Now carry that identity into SMS. Don't start over with an abbreviated business name and accidentally open another carrier.

Write the confirmed USDOT number and legal name at the top of W04. Open https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/ and search that USDOT number. Compare the result with your identity worksheet. Record the lookup date, the data-through date, and the website update date when shown. Those dates answer different questions: when you looked, how recent the data is, and when the site was refreshed.

Review the Motor Carrier Overview and the available BASIC information, Summary of Activities, investigation information, and registration details. The exact layout can change. Use the official Help Center if a section has moved. You are looking for the data behind the summary, not a color that tells you what to think.

For a public property-carrier review, expect the percentile restrictions. Don't keep searching for a hidden private rank as though it were a missing public button. Read available measures and supporting inspection details. Note the categories you cannot inspect publicly. The learner's diagram in this book shows a route through sources; it isn't a reproduction of a government interface.

In Pine Ridge's fictional packet, the identity is fixed as TRAINING-PINE, not a valid USDOT number. Use the supplied files for the actual classroom analysis. If you practice locating fields on a real public record, keep that exercise separate from the fictional case and don't publish an unsupported judgment about the real carrier. A site-navigation exercise isn't a completed carrier investigation.

09 The public review route

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1-2	SAFER: search and confirm USDOT identity
3	L&I: authority and filing review
4-5	SMS: search matching carrier; review overview
6	Data Downloads / BASIC Data Center
7	Save available Excel/XLS or XML and source dates
8	Review events and complete seven-BASIC worksheet

A source-routing diagram, not a government screen. Confirm actual controls in the current site.

Instructional figure 09. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Losing the confirmed identity between SAFER and SMS.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to create a breadcrumb with source, legal name, number type, lookup time, and data-through date. Automatic cross-site safety retrieval is not verified here.

Try it

Create the breadcrumb for the Pine Ridge training packet and identify each date you would preserve from a live SMS view.

Think it through

Could another reviewer reproduce your search without guessing which company you meant?

Check your understanding

1. Is the lookup date necessarily the data-through date?

2. Is a hidden property-carrier percentile a sign of a clean record?

Take this with you

Carry identity and dates through every source.

Sources: F01, F02, F08. See source ledger for verification status.

05.02 | Download all available data or one BASIC

A screenshot can show a summary. A download helps you organize the events behind it. Before you download, decide whether you need one category or all the data available to your access level.

From the matching SMS carrier overview, locate Data Downloads or the BASIC detail Data Center. The official Help Center documents Excel/XLS and XML options for a selected BASIC or all BASICs. Select the appropriate scope and format, then save the file. “All” means all available within that system, period, and permission level. It doesn't mean every infraction in the company’s lifetime.

Keep the original download unchanged. Name it with the carrier identifier, PUBLIC-SMS, and retrieval date. Make a working copy for sorting and notes. Record the actual filename and format; don't rename an XML file with an XLSX extension and expect it to become a spreadsheet. Preserve the source URL and displayed snapshot date beside the file.

Open the file and inspect its real columns and tabs before building formulas. Federal export layouts may differ from the classroom CSVs. Find the report identifiers, dates, descriptions, OOS fields, and applicable inspection totals that are actually present. If clean inspections aren't included in the rows you have, don't calculate an OOS rate from that subset alone.

Our practice pack uses a deliberately simple schema and text-only training identifiers. Pine Ridge has a separate inspection list and violation list. That separation makes the denominator visible. No file in the practice pack is an authentic federal export. Use it to learn the reasoning, then map the concepts carefully to an actual authorized download.

09 The public review route

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1-2	SAFER: search and confirm USDOT identity
3	L&I: authority and filing review
4-5	SMS: search matching carrier; review overview
6	Data Downloads / BASIC Data Center
7	Save available Excel/XLS or XML and source dates
8	Review events and complete seven-BASIC worksheet

A source-routing diagram, not a government screen. Confirm actual controls in the current site.

Instructional figure 09. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Assuming a file named “all BASICs” includes private driver histories or unlimited years.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: A future import tool could summarize authorized exports. For now, the book teaches manual download and review; automatic SMS ingestion is proposed and unverified.

Try it

Open both Pine Ridge CSVs. Identify which one supplies inspection counts and which supplies violation detail. Save your working notes without changing the originals.

Think it through

What would you lose if you kept only the sorted working copy?

Check your understanding

1. Which formats does the SMS Help Center describe?

2. Can a violation-only subset supply a full OOS denominator?

Take this with you

Preserve the original export and understand its scope before calculating.

Sources: F01, F02. See source ledger for verification status.

05.03 | Read rows without making accusations

Three rows don't necessarily mean three stops. A report identifier connects entries to the inspection where they occurred. A violation identifier distinguishes findings inside that event. Mixing the two can make a carrier's record look worse than the evidence supports.

In Pine Ridge's fictional data, inspection PR-I01 has brake and tire violation rows. Both belong to one vehicle OOS inspection. PR-I02 is another vehicle OOS inspection with a brake finding. Several other inspections have lamp findings without vehicle OOS. You must count unique inspection IDs for the inspection numerator and denominator, while retaining all violation rows for the pattern analysis.

First sort the inspection list by date and ID. Check eligibility fields for vehicle and driver inspection calculations. Then connect violation rows to those IDs. Confirm that every violation has a parent inspection. If two rows use the same ID but conflict on date or unit, investigate the discrepancy rather than silently selecting one value. Preserve the original data and explain any correction you make in the working copy.

Read the description and regulation code where provided. Our fictional records use descriptive training codes rather than pretending to reproduce an exact federal violation-code list. A real code should be checked against the current applicable description. Don't assign an official severity weight to a made-up training code.

Finally, distinguish observation from interpretation. "Two separate brake-related vehicle OOS inspections" is an observed pattern in the sample. "The owner refuses to maintain trucks" is an unsupported claim about motive. Ask which units were affected, what repairs occurred, and whether a recurring process failure was identified. If the record is factually wrong, preserve evidence for an appropriate DataQs review.

10 One inspection, multiple findings

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Inspection ID	Finding	Vehicle OOS
INS-101	Brake	Yes
INS-101	Tire	Yes
INS-102	Lamp	No
Totals	3 violation rows; 2 inspections	1 OOS inspection

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. This two-inspection example is separate from the Pine Ridge dataset.

Instructional figure 10. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating a duplicated row as a new inspection or silently deleting an inconvenient finding.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to count distinct IDs and flag conflicts in the fictional data. Proposed analysis must show its counting method so a person can check it.

Try it

Count Pine Ridge's eligible vehicle inspections, driver inspections, vehicle OOS inspections, driver OOS inspections, and violation rows. Explain why these totals differ.

Think it through

Can your conclusion be traced to an event, or only to an impression?

Check your understanding

1. How many inspections are represented by two violations sharing one valid inspection ID?

2. Should a disputed valid-looking row be removed from your source copy?

Take this with you

Count events accurately and keep interpretation separate from fact.

Sources: F02, F19. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 05 | Audit the export

Use: W04

Open both Pine Ridge CSVs. Count distinct inspection IDs, eligible inspections, OOS outcomes, and violation rows. Identify the two rows on PR-I01.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

06 | Find patterns without inventing causes

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

06.01 | Repeated maintenance trouble

One defect requires attention. Repeated defects require you to examine both the individual repairs and the process that allowed the problem to recur. That doesn't mean you already know who is to blame.

Pine Ridge’s sample contains two brake-related vehicle OOS inspections, including one inspection with a tire finding as well. Start with the affected unit and inspection date. Ask for the repair record that addresses the cited condition, who completed or verified the work, and the release-to-service evidence. Match the evidence to the unit. An invoice for another tractor doesn't close this item.

Then ask how the defect was found and reported. Did the driver report it before the stop? Was it scheduled for repair? Was a replacement part unavailable? Were inspection procedures followed? These are questions, not conclusions. A carrier may show that one defect was sudden and another arose from a repeat process weakness. The response should fit the facts.

Look beyond “we fixed it.” A completed repair addresses the immediate condition. A preventive-maintenance schedule, defect-reporting procedure, responsible person, and follow-up inspection address recurrence. If the same issue appears again, reopen the cause analysis. Don't assume a signed form means the physical condition was corrected.

For a new load, hold while a material maintenance concern remains unresolved. If a current OOS condition applies to the proposed equipment, stop that equipment’s assignment until lawful return-to-service conditions are met. If repairs and controls are convincingly documented, reassess fairly. The purpose is safer operation and a defensible decision, not permanent punishment for every old defect.

11 Follow the maintenance pattern

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Fictional date	Observed issue	Evidence to request
February	Brake defect	Unit-matched repair
March	Tire defect	Replacement / inspection
April	Brake defect	Cause and prior action review
May	Brake OOS	Correction and lawful release

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Illustrative sequence, not Pine Ridge event dates or official severity weights.

Instructional figure 11. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Calling a shop negligent without evidence or treating a generic repair invoice as sufficient proof.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to connect inspection, unit, requested evidence, response, and recheck date. An integrated corrective-action coach is proposed, not verified live.

Try it

Complete W05 for Pine Ridge with three repair questions and two process questions. Mark each answer as claimed or independently supported.

Think it through

Does the evidence show that the defect was fixed, that recurrence was addressed, or both?

Check your understanding

1. What connects a repair to an inspection finding?

2. Must a repaired carrier remain on hold forever?

Take this with you

Verify the repair and examine why the problem repeated.

Sources: F02. See source ledger for verification status.

06.02 | Repeated driving and HOS behavior

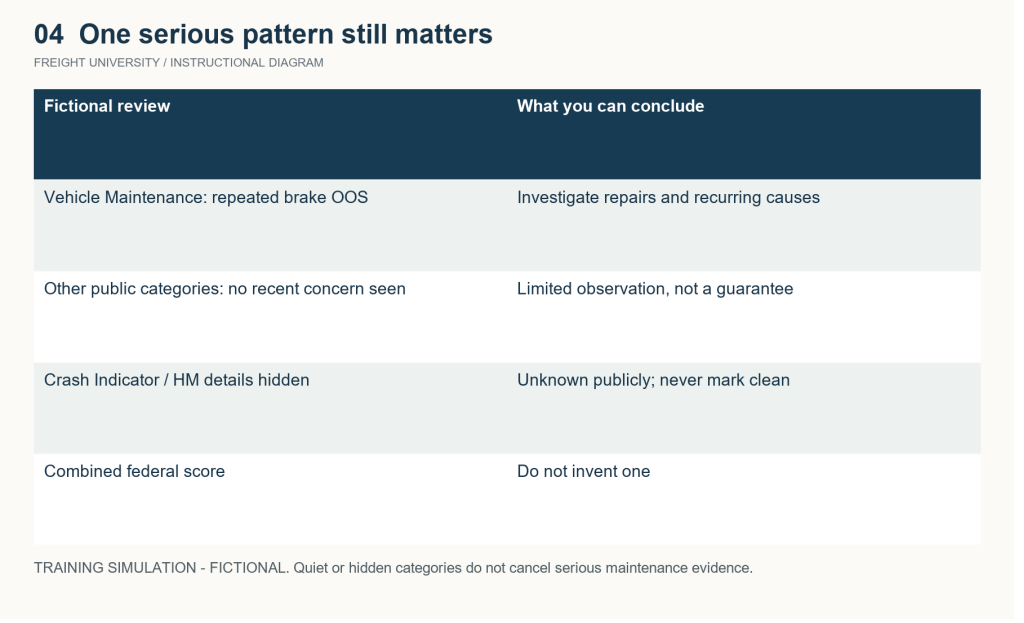
Delta Interstate has zero driver OOS inspections out of twenty in the classroom sample. That sounds reassuring until you read the speeding and cellphone entries. OOS is a particular outcome, not a synonym for every safety concern.

Arrange the events by date and theme. Count separate inspections, not repeated copies of the same entry. Ask whether a pattern involves the same driver, several drivers, a route, a time pressure, or something you cannot establish from the available data. Public fields may not support every comparison. If you don't have a reliable driver link, don't invent one.

The carrier’s response should address observed conduct. Coaching may be appropriate, but a statement that everybody attended a meeting doesn't prove the conduct changed. Ask how the carrier checks improvement and what it does when unsafe behavior repeats. A pattern involving several drivers may justify examining broader scheduling and supervision practices, while still avoiding unsupported claims about cause.

HOS review requires similar care. A route plan should allow lawful driving, required breaks, loading delays, and realistic appointment timing. If the schedule becomes unworkable, the response should be to revise the plan, not pressure the driver to hide time. But a public log finding alone doesn't establish who created the problem. Inspect the actual record and ask a neutral question.

In a small fleet, repeated driving events can create business uncertainty as well as safety exposure. A customer may ask questions, or an insurer may review the record. Those are possible consequences, not guaranteed outcomes. Keep the carrier’s operational response at the center of the review instead of predicting an exact premium increase or lost revenue.



04 One serious pattern still matters

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Fictional review	What you can conclude
Vehicle Maintenance: repeated brake OOS	Investigate repairs and recurring causes
Other public categories: no recent concern seen	Limited observation, not a guarantee
Crash Indicator / HM details hidden	Unknown publicly; never mark clean
Combined federal score	Do not invent one

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Quiet or hidden categories do not cancel serious maintenance evidence.

Instructional figure 04. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Equating zero OOS with zero violations, or treating a possible business consequence as certain.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to group fictional events by date and behavior, then list questions. Automated behavior monitoring is proposed and must not assign motive.

Try it

Write a three-sentence Delta summary: observed rate, separate violation pattern, and evidence needed before a decision.

Think it through

What would demonstrate changed behavior after coaching?

Check your understanding

1. Can a carrier have a 0% driver OOS rate and repeated unsafe-driving findings?

2. Does a cluster prove dispatch pressure caused it?

Take this with you

Examine the conduct even when the OOS count is zero.

Sources: F02. See source ledger for verification status.

06.03 | Crashes, thin data, and identity changes

Three carriers can present three very different uncertainties: a crash, no inspections, and an identity mismatch. Calling all three “high risk” without explanation doesn't tell a reviewer what to do next.

Golden Plains has one reported crash in the fictional packet. Its driver says the truck was legally stopped when struck. Read the police report and preserve relevant video or photographs if lawfully available. Determine whether an official preventability review exists. Don't replace a crash count with a fault finding, and don't accept a favorable narrative as a completed agency determination.

Cedar Valley has no vehicle inspections in the sample. Its missing inspection history leaves a gap. Verify the appropriate authority and insurance, readiness of equipment, and the carrier’s qualification and maintenance controls. A new entrant can be legitimate and well prepared. Thin data means you must be explicit about what other evidence supports the decision.

Bayou has conflicting identity and payment information. Start with independent contact verification. Don't use only the phone number supplied in the questionable message to validate that same message. Confirm the legal entity through official sources and established insurer or carrier contacts. A recent address change can be legitimate, but the explanation needs support before you connect the packet to a truck or payment instruction.

The right disposition follows the unresolved issue. Golden Plains needs evidence-based crash review. Cedar Valley needs readiness evidence despite limited observations. Bayou’s transaction stops until identity is established. None of these statements accuses a real business. All names and evidence in the case pack are fictional, and no training identifier is a real authority number.

07 Sparse data needs care

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

OOS / inspections	Simple rate	Interpretation
0 / 0	Undefined	No observations
1 / 2	50%	Very small sample
2 / 8	25%	Small sample
20 / 100	20%	Broader sample, still limited

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Rates alone do not establish a carrier safety verdict.

Instructional figure 07. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Using one generic risk label for unrelated problems that require different checks.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT for three separate unknowns and three source-specific next actions. Integrated fraud or SMS conclusions are not verified capabilities here.

Try it

Assign a preliminary disposition to Golden Plains, Cedar Valley, and Bayou. State what evidence could change each one.

Think it through

Are you responding to an observed defect, missing information, or an identity problem?

Check your understanding

1. Does a new authority with no inspections automatically fail?

2. Should an unresolved material identity mismatch be ignored because safety data looks good?

Take this with you

Match the next action to the actual uncertainty.

Sources: F08, F09, F20. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 06 | Patterns and fair questions

Use: W04, W05

Compare Pine Ridge maintenance and Delta driving events. Write two observed facts, two possible causes, and evidence requests.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

07 | Approve the carrier without guessing

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

07.01 | A broker’s first-load review

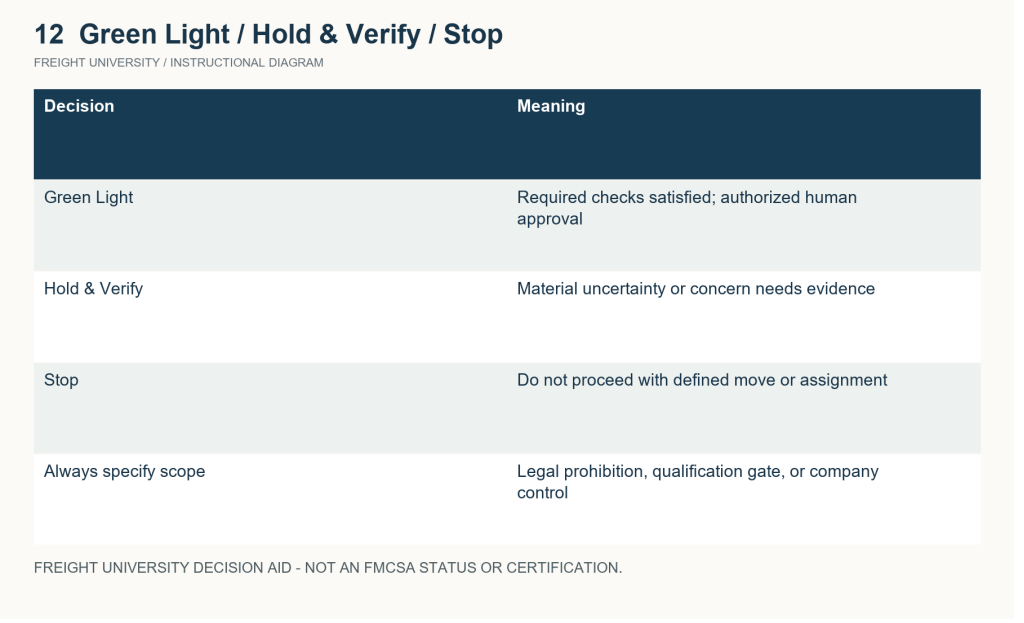
The load is ready, and the carrier says it can be there in an hour. Speed matters, but the first-load review still has to connect the right company, appropriate authority, suitable equipment, coverage, and a documented safety review.

Begin with the shipment: commodity, value, origin and destination, equipment, timing, and customer requirements. Then verify the legal carrier and authenticated contact. Check the applicable authority and insurance filings, and complete the needed coverage verification. Review public safety information with its dates and limitations. An old packet can be useful background without being sufficient current evidence.

Confirm that the truck and assigned driver are coming through the carrier’s authorized dispatch process. The carrier remains responsible for driver qualification. A broker should not treat routine onboarding as permission to collect medical details, PSP reports, or Clearinghouse records. Ask for relevant operational confirmation within the broker’s lawful role rather than demanding an entire private file.

For Pine Ridge, the public review reveals repeat maintenance OOS events. Ask which equipment is proposed and what documented corrections address the concern. A current legal status check and a repair review answer different questions. If company policy requires safety-manager review for this pattern, record that policy as the reason for the additional gate; don't call it a federal ban.

Finish with a specific decision memo. Identify the move and carrier, list the sources and dates, summarize unresolved issues, and name the authorized reviewer. Green Light applies only after the required checks and material concerns are resolved. If a hold remains, state what evidence is needed and who will review it. An urgent pickup doesn't turn an unknown into a verified fact.



12 Green Light / Hold & Verify / Stop

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Decision	Meaning
Green Light	Required checks satisfied; authorized human approval
Hold & Verify	Material uncertainty or concern needs evidence
Stop	Do not proceed with defined move or assignment
Always specify scope	Legal prohibition, qualification gate, or company control

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY DECISION AID - NOT AN FMCSA STATUS OR CERTIFICATION.

Instructional figure 12. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Approving a carrier because the packet is complete-looking while identity or coverage remains unverified.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to draft a source-backed first-load checklist. The handoff describes carrier lookup; added SMS and driver analysis are proposed and require verification.

Try it

Complete W06 for a Pine Ridge first load. Keep the disposition on hold until your listed evidence is supplied.

Think it through

Which parts of your review concern this particular shipment?

Check your understanding

1. Does a broker normally own the hiring carrier’s driver qualification file?

2. Can customer policy be stricter than the minimum legal operating status?

Take this with you

Approve the defined carrier for the defined move with traceable evidence.

Sources: F08, F09, F13, F17. See source ledger for verification status.

07.02 | A dispatcher’s new carrier client

A dispatcher is building a relationship, not just booking one load. That makes it useful to understand the carrier’s equipment, operating areas, availability, and safety practices before promising work on its behalf.

Confirm the legal carrier, your agreement and scope of authority, and the operation you are supporting. Know which equipment is available, who can authorize assignments, and how the carrier communicates a defect or driver-availability problem. Don't make promises that require an unavailable truck or a driver who cannot lawfully perform the trip.

Use official public sources for identity, authority, and available safety information. Ask the carrier to address material concerns through its responsible safety or maintenance person. If the carrier grants access to its internal records, use only the authorized role and purpose. Being a dispatcher doesn't automatically make you the employer, safety manager, or a permissible user of every protected driver record.

Pine Ridge wants dispatch support after two maintenance OOS inspections. You can explain the concern without condemning the company: “I need to understand which units were affected, what was repaired, and which equipment is ready for the loads we discuss.” Record the evidence and the owner’s plan. Hold representation for affected work while material readiness questions remain unresolved.

Once work begins, plan around realistic travel and duty time. If loading delays break the original schedule, escalate and revise the appointment plan. Don't ask the driver to solve the problem by falsifying records. A good dispatcher makes lawful operation easier to maintain and leaves qualification and equipment-release decisions with the responsible carrier personnel.

16 Whose authority applies?

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Arrangement	Carrier review
Travis leased under Pine Ridge	Pine Ridge retains applicable safety duties
Travis as separate operating carrier	Evaluate his actual carrier authority and duties
Owns tractor	Does not by itself answer responsibility
Contractor label	Does not erase applicable carrier obligations

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Verify the actual operating arrangement.

Instructional figure 16. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Acting as though a dispatch agreement transfers all carrier safety duties to the dispatcher.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT for a carrier-client onboarding checklist and a list of open evidence requests. Automatic safety monitoring and reminders are proposed unless separately verified and authorized.

Try it

Write a Pine Ridge onboarding note covering scope, equipment, contacts, current holds, and the process for reporting a new defect.

Think it through

Who can stop an assignment when the truck or driver isn't ready?

Check your understanding

1. Does dispatching alone authorize private driver queries?

2. What should happen when a delay makes the schedule unworkable?

Take this with you

Support the carrier’s operation without assuming duties or access you don't hold.

Sources: F08, F09, F15. See source ledger for verification status.

07.03 | A fair decision and a recheck routine

A decision is easier to defend when another person can follow the path from evidence to action. Use seven elements: source, observed fact, concern, response, disposition, reviewer, and date. Add the next-review trigger so the file doesn't become a forgotten approval.

Start with a narrow fact. “The training inspection list contains two vehicle OOS inspections among eight eligible vehicle inspections” is reproducible. “Bad carrier” is not. Explain why the fact matters, what you asked, and what evidence came back. If the carrier supplied an explanation but no supporting record, mark it as a statement awaiting corroboration.

Then write the disposition and scope. A hold on a particular tractor is different from a hold on all new business. A legal prohibition is different from a company’s unresolved policy concern. If approval is conditional on using a verified replacement unit, state the condition clearly and ensure it is actually checked before assignment. Don't use vague conditions that nobody owns.

Rechecks should respond to the type of risk. Verify current material status before tender under your process. Review newly available SMS data on the monthly cycle, recognizing that source refresh dates can vary. React promptly to a new prohibition, serious defect, identity change, or significant incident. A scheduled monthly review isn't permission to ignore an urgent problem today.

In Pine Ridge’s case, a later packet may contain matching repair evidence and subsequent inspection records. Reassess it rather than copying the old hold forever. Keep the earlier memo, add the new evidence, and explain why the decision changed. An audit trail is a sequence of reasoned decisions, not a single permanent label.

19 The corrective-action circle

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1	Read the report and verify the facts
2	Investigate cause without assuming motive
3	Repair, coach, or correct qualification controls
4	Preserve proof and verify completion
5	Monitor later evidence and effectiveness
6	Reassess the human decision

Continue operating only where lawful. A calendar does not guarantee score repair.

Instructional figure 19. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Letting a prior approval override a material new fact.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to draft a change summary from two dated fictional packets. Automated audit trails and review notifications are proposed; a person must verify and approve any action.

Try it

Write a one-page memo using W06. Include one event-based recheck trigger and one scheduled review date.

Think it through

Could a reviewer tell why you changed the decision without asking you?

Check your understanding

1. Should a carrier statement be labeled independently verified?

2. Does a monthly review schedule replace immediate response to a legal stop?

Take this with you

Preserve the reasoning and revisit it when the facts change.

Sources: F01, F08, F09. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 07 | Carrier memo

Use: W06

Write a first-load Pine Ridge memo with scope, evidence, unknowns, and a release condition.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

08 | Driver history: find the record, don't invent the story

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

08.01 | An application is a timeline, not proof

Robert Miller lists six employers in three years. Your first job isn't to decide that he quits too much. Your first job is to understand what he reported and what can be verified.

Under the applicable driver-application rules in 49 CFR 391.21, employment history includes the preceding three years. For drivers of vehicles requiring a CDL, the application also calls for the additional history of employers for whom the applicant operated a commercial motor vehicle during the preceding ten years. These are different history requirements. Ten years doesn't mean every type of job for every applicant.

Build a timeline with reported employer, start and end dates, job role, and whether the work involved a CDL-required CMV. Mark gaps and overlaps without filling them in yourself. Seasonal work, company closures, family needs, staffing arrangements, and leased operations can explain a complicated history. An explanation is a starting point for corroboration, not automatic proof or automatic deception.

Our Robert file includes overlapping seasonal work. Elena Carter’s fictional history includes two company closures. Aaron Brooks reports one employer, while a properly obtained PSP event refers to another carrier. For Aaron, ask whether the event involved a lease, staffing assignment, fleet owner, or omitted employment. An event-associated carrier name doesn't automatically identify the payroll employer.

Keep the process consistent and job-related. Apply the same relevant standards across applicants. Record the question, answer, and evidence rather than a character judgment. When covered consumer reports inform employment decisions, applicable FCRA procedures and other laws also matter. A general application signature doesn't automatically satisfy every separate disclosure or consent requirement.



14 Reconcile a timeline fairly

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Fictional Robert record	Question
Six jobs across three years	Which dates and roles are reported?
Two seasonal jobs overlap	Was this concurrent work?
PSP event carrier differs	Lease, staffing, fleet owner, or omission?
MVR and some replies pending	What is still unverified?

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. A discrepancy is a question, not a dishonesty verdict.

Instructional figure 14. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating the number of employers as a safety verdict or claiming PSP lists every job separation.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: In a properly authorized carrier context, ask MT to organize reported dates and unanswered questions. Private timeline interpretation is a proposed aid; it doesn't verify employment by itself.

Try it

Use W07 to map Robert’s six reported jobs. Mark the overlap and draft a neutral question about it.

Think it through

Would your question allow an honest explanation, or does it already assume misconduct?

Check your understanding

1. Is an application’s employment history independently verified?

2. Does the ten-year requirement cover every job for every applicant?

Take this with you

Reconstruct the timeline before judging it.

Sources: F14, F15, F18. See source ledger for verification status.

08.02 | Confirm employers and obtain the MVR

The application gives you claims. The investigation checks those claims and the driver's qualifications. A motor vehicle record, or MVR, comes from the relevant state licensing authority or a lawful provider. It isn't the same thing as PSP.

For the applicable 391.23 inquiry, identify each state where the driver held a motor-vehicle license during the preceding three years. Use that state agency's official driving-record process or an authorized provider. Confirm the permissible purpose, required authorization, record type, and identity match. There is no single public FMCSA page where a broker can retrieve every driver's MVR.

Review license status, class, endorsements, restrictions, and reported violations or convictions within the record's scope. Reconcile the information with the application and the intended operation. A plastic card alone may not establish current status. For applicable CDL medical qualification documentation, follow current 391.23 and 391.51 requirements and the state record process; don't assume an old photocopy settles the question.

Investigate required prior-employer safety performance under 391.23. Record the inquiry, attempts, response, dates, and unresolved discrepancies. Certain investigation requirements have deadlines tied to the first 30 days of employment. That does not move pre-service qualification, required testing, or Clearinghouse gates to day 30. Separate the deadlines on your checklist. Annual MVR inquiry and review under 391.25 are continuing duties, not a replacement for the initial process.

Robert has two employer replies and an MVR still pending. That means the classroom file remains incomplete, not that he has failed. If a covered consumer report may lead to an adverse employment decision, follow the applicable pre-adverse process, including the report copy and rights summary, then the required adverse-action notice if the decision is made. Allow the applicable opportunity to review or dispute; do not invent one universal waiting period for every jurisdiction.

13 Three different driver records

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Application	MVR	PSP
Reported work history	State license / driving record	FMCSA event data
Investigate required history	Lawful state/provider access	5 years crashes; 3 years inspections
Not independently proven	Not PSP	Not every employer or separation

Protected records require the correct role, lawful purpose, and consent where required.

Instructional figure 13. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Assuming all checks can wait 30 days or treating an unanswered employer inquiry as proof of misconduct.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Compliance Pro publicly describes application and file tracking. Its page says users obtain MVRs through official providers; automatic ordering isn't offered there. A tracking status doesn't prove a check was completed.

Try it

Put Robert’s items into completed, pending before service, and inquiry/documentation follow-up categories. Explain any company policy that is stricter than the minimum timing rule.

Think it through

Does your checklist distinguish “requested” from “received and reviewed”?

Check your understanding

1. Where does an MVR originate?

2. Does a 30-day inquiry deadline allow covered pre-service gates to be postponed?

Take this with you

Track requests, results, review, and deadlines separately.

Sources: F14, F15, F18. See source ledger for verification status.

08.03 | PSP: five years and three years

PSP stands for Pre-Employment Screening Program. Its report contains five years of crash data and three years of roadside inspection data from FMCSA's MCMIS system. It is a useful optional screening source for an authorized prospective employer, not a complete biography.

Start at https://www.psp.fmcsa.dot.gov/. Review the current employer enrollment and consent instructions before ordering. The prospective employer must obtain the required written authorization and use the report for the permitted pre-employment purpose. A driver can obtain their own record. This book's live request encountered an offline message; these are source-based procedural directions, not a claim that an order was completed or the authenticated screens were tested.

Read the report dates and event-associated carriers. A carrier listed for an inspection identifies the carrier associated with that event. It doesn't prove who paid the driver, every job the driver held, why the driver left, or whether a listed crash was the driver's fault. PSP doesn't replace a state MVR, required employer investigation, or Clearinghouse query.

Robert's training file has four inspection events and two speeding-related findings. Compare those dates with his reported work history, then ask about differences. Don't assume four inspections mean four employers. Aaron's mismatch is another reason to ask about the operating arrangement and obtain corroboration. The goal is to understand the record accurately, not turn every difference into a dishonesty finding.

Don't confuse PSP with an enforcement driver measurement system or a supposed public personal CSA score. No broker search in this course exposes a driver's private federal rank. Store authorized reports securely, limit access, preserve consent evidence, and follow the applicable retention and reporting requirements. Use the synthetic practice file for class rather than a real applicant's report.

13 Three different driver records

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Application	MVR	PSP
Reported work history	State license / driving record	FMCSA event data
Investigate required history	Lawful state/provider access	5 years crashes; 3 years inspections
Not independently proven	Not PSP	Not every employer or separation

Protected records require the correct role, lawful purpose, and consent where required.

Instructional figure 13. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Calling PSP a complete employment, resignation, conviction, or fault database.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to compare fictional event dates with reported employment dates. Secure interpretation of actual authorized PSP reports is proposed; the book does not establish automatic ordering or live report analysis.

Try it

Compare Robert's two CSV files. Write one supported observation and one question the files cannot answer.

Think it through

What conclusion would be tempting but unsupported by an event-associated carrier name?

Check your understanding

1. Is PSP mandatory for every hire?

2. Does PSP replace the MVR or Clearinghouse?

Take this with you

Use PSP for its defined events and windows, not an invented life story.

Sources: F13, F24. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 08 | Employment timeline

Use: W07, W09

Map Robert and Elena. Mark Robert seasonal overlap. Explain Aaron’s event-carrier mismatch with neutral questions.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

09 | Keep a bad hire from breaking the carrier

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

09.01 | Clearinghouse, testing, and qualification

A signed application isn't permission to put the driver behind the wheel. Before covered safety-sensitive work, the employer must complete the applicable qualification and drug/alcohol gates. A task marked “requested” is still pending.

For a driver covered by Part 382, the employer conducts the required full pre-employment Clearinghouse query. Start with the official Clearinghouse site, review the employer instructions, and use the authorized employer or properly designated service-agent account. Request the appropriate full query and obtain the driver’s specific electronic consent inside Clearinghouse. Review the completed result and any prohibition. A general e-signature or a limited-query consent stored in another application doesn't replace that specific consent.

The query is separate from the applicable pre-employment controlled-substances test. Under 382.301, the employer must receive a verified negative result before covered safety-sensitive duties unless it properly meets and documents a regulatory exception. Don't infer an exception merely because the applicant says a previous employer tested them. The exception has specific conditions and verification duties. A scheduled test, pending result, or unrelated medical examination is not a verified negative result.

Check the required CDL class, endorsements, restrictions, physical qualification, road test or permitted equivalent, and other applicable driver qualifications. Organize required DQF records under 391.51, while keeping sensitive drug/alcohol records subject to their separate confidentiality and retention rules. A convenient software checklist doesn't make every listed document an identical statutory DQF item.

Ongoing duties continue after hire. Covered employers query Clearinghouse at least annually. A properly consented limited query can satisfy that annual query requirement, but information returned requires a full query within 24 hours; follow the rule’s restrictions if it isn't completed. The employer must also meet annual MVR review and other continuing obligations. Robert’s fictional pending full query means no covered safety-sensitive assignment, regardless of how urgently a truck needs a driver.

15 Qualification is more than a signature

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Gate or task	Check
Application / inquiries	Signed history; required investigation
License / medical / road test	Applicable qualifications and evidence
Optional PSP	Permitted purpose and written authorization
Full Clearinghouse query	Required specific electronic consent and result
Required controlled-substances test	Verified negative or documented lawful exception
Human review	Apply each timing rule; do not assume 30-day grace

Illustrative checklist. Inquiry deadlines and pre-service gates differ.

Instructional figure 15. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating consent, a submitted query, and a completed eligible result as the same status.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Compliance Pro publicly describes file and date tracking, while saying MVRs and Clearinghouse queries are obtained through official providers. Its general consent workflow doesn't replace full-query electronic consent. No live private query was performed for this book.

Try it

Complete W08 for Robert. Circle every pre-service item still pending, identify its owner, and keep the assignment blocked until the applicable requirements are met.

Think it through

Could your dashboard say “active” while a required qualification task is still incomplete?

Check your understanding

1. Is an application e-signature enough for a full Clearinghouse query?

2. Does a completed Clearinghouse query replace pre-employment testing?

Take this with you

Verify each required gate before covered work begins.

Sources: F15, F16, F17, F26, F27. See source ledger for verification status.

09.02 | Owner-operators and leased-on drivers

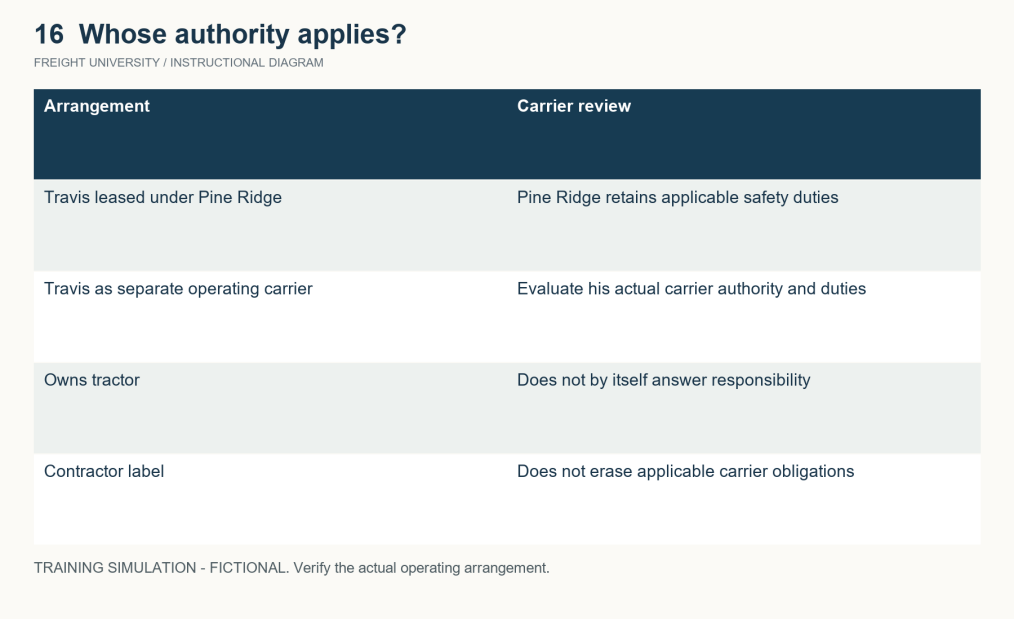
Travis owns his tractor. Pine Ridge supplies the operating authority for the loads in our fictional arrangement. Who must ensure the driver and equipment meet the applicable safety requirements? The word “owner-operator” doesn't answer that question by itself.

Start with the operating arrangement. Identify the motor carrier under whose authority and USDOT identity the trip is performed. Determine who directs the operation and which carrier duties apply. A driver’s independent-contractor label or separate business name doesn't automatically release the operating carrier from driver qualification and safety obligations.

For Travis operating under Pine Ridge, the carrier must address its applicable qualification, testing, maintenance, and operational duties. Owning a tractor doesn't supply a completed driver file. A lease doesn't turn an unqualified driver into a qualified one. The actual agreement and operation need review; this lesson isn't a template for deciding employment classification or tax status.

Now change the facts. Travis operates as a separate motor carrier under his own applicable authority and contracts to haul the shipment. The carrier-selection review must evaluate that actual operating carrier. You don't substitute Pine Ridge’s record because the two companies have worked together. If an entity is arranging another carrier’s transportation, additional brokerage or contracting questions may arise; resolve the real role rather than hiding it behind “owner-operator.”

Write the responsible carrier in the load file and the driver-qualification process. Confirm it matches the authority, dispatch arrangement, equipment documentation, and insurance review. If those records point to different businesses, stop and reconcile them. Responsibility should be clear before the load moves, not reconstructed after a problem.



16 Whose authority applies?

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Arrangement	Carrier review
Travis leased under Pine Ridge	Pine Ridge retains applicable safety duties
Travis as separate operating carrier	Evaluate his actual carrier authority and duties
Owns tractor	Does not by itself answer responsibility
Contractor label	Does not erase applicable carrier obligations

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL. Verify the actual operating arrangement.

Instructional figure 16. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Assuming tractor ownership or a contractor label transfers the operating carrier's federal safety duties away.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to map owner, driver, operating carrier, and contracting party from fictional facts. The map is proposed decision support, not a legal determination of the arrangement.

Try it

Identify the carrier for four arrangements: Travis leased to Pine Ridge; Travis hauling under his own authority; an employee in a Pine Ridge-owned tractor; a staffed driver operating a Pine Ridge load. State what additional facts you'd verify.

Think it through

Which document and operational fact establish whose authority applies to this trip?

Check your understanding

1. Does owning the truck eliminate driver qualification duties?

2. Should a separate carrier use another company's safety record for approval?

Take this with you

Follow the operating arrangement, not the label on the driver's business card.

Sources: F15, F22. See source ledger for verification status.

09.03 | One hire and the whole small company

Imagine a fictional owner who has invested $100,000 in equipment, insurance, and startup costs. That figure is a teaching assumption, not a claim about the cost of starting every carrier. The owner hires a third driver and expects the new truck to help pay the bills.

In April, the new driver has following-too-close and seat-belt findings. In June, a separate inspection records speeding. In August, a trailer brake condition results in vehicle OOS. These are Blue Ridge's sample events. The first two dates raise driving-behavior questions. The August event raises equipment and maintenance questions. The chronology doesn't prove that the driver caused every issue.

What happens next depends partly on the carrier's response. Did it review the April report promptly? Did it verify the facts, coach the driver, and check whether behavior changed? Did it inspect and repair the trailer, determine why the defect occurred, and confirm readiness before return to service? A file containing only the inspection reports documents the problem but not the response.

The events can remain part of the carrier's applicable historical safety data even if the driver leaves. A customer may ask for explanations. An insurer may review the record. Work opportunities could be affected. Don't promise a particular loss, premium change, or percentile movement. The business lesson is that one assignment affects a shared operating record and deserves timely management attention.

Fairness still matters. Don't use the owner's financial stress as a reason to skip screening, pressure the driver, or invent fault. Don't blame a driver for an equipment condition without investigation. Use an issue-to-action-to-recheck chain: what happened, what evidence supports the cause, what changed, and what later evidence shows. That chain helps protect the driver, the carrier, the freight, and the public.

08 A moving record window

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Illustrative event age	Review question
3 months	What happened recently and what changed?
10 months	Did the response prevent recurrence?
20 months	Is this still inside the relevant window?
Current carrier SMS: rolling 24 months	Do not confuse with PSP 5/3-year windows

Age, severity, exposure, and category rules matter. No exact rank change is implied.

Instructional figure 08. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Believing termination erases valid history or that every equipment defect is the driver's fault.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to build Blue Ridge's dated issue/action/recheck list. An integrated CSA coach is proposed; historical event removal and financial outcomes cannot be promised.

Try it

Create three corrective-action entries for Blue Ridge, keeping driving behavior separate from the brake investigation.

Think it through

What early action could have revealed whether the April response was working?

Check your understanding

1. Is the $100,000 figure a universal startup requirement?

2. Will replacing the driver erase the carrier's earlier valid events?

Take this with you

Respond early and verify the response instead of relying on turnover.

Sources: F02, F03. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 09 | Qualification gates

Use: W08

Compare PSP, MVR, and Clearinghouse. Identify Robert's pre-service block and Travis's responsible carrier.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

10 | When the government pays attention

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

10.01 | Intervention thresholds and outcomes

An elevated BASIC percentile can draw agency attention. It isn't the same thing as an order to stop operating. This distinction matters both to the carrier receiving attention and to the broker reviewing its records.

The current threshold reference uses three carrier groups: general, placardable hazardous materials, and passenger. For Unsafe Driving, Crash Indicator, and HOS, the respective thresholds are 65, 60, and 50. For Vehicle Maintenance, Controlled Substances/Alcohol, and Driver Fitness, they are 80, 75, and 65. HM Compliance uses 80 in all three columns. These are intervention thresholds, not load-approval grades.

Confirm the applicable criteria and current methodology on the official SMS page. Public property-carrier percentiles and prioritization indicators remain restricted, so a broker cannot pretend to independently observe them in the public view. If the carrier provides private evidence appropriately, preserve that source distinction.

Interventions can include warning letters, targeted roadside inspection attention, and offsite or onsite investigations. Outcomes depend on the facts and applicable process. Don't draw an automatic staircase in which every warning inevitably becomes a shutdown. Investigations may reveal violations requiring action; formal orders and effective dates must be read on their own terms.

Suppose a fictional carrier-provided training statement says an applicable category crossed its threshold. The right response is to understand the category, date, source, underlying events, and carrier response. You may require additional review under policy. You cannot rewrite that statement as “authority revoked” without official evidence of that action. A strong review keeps prioritization, rating, authority, and prohibition in separate fields.

17 Intervention is not automatic shutdown

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Observed information	Interpretation
Elevated applicable BASIC percentile	May support intervention prioritization
Warning / investigation	Read actual notice and required action
Final effective prohibition / OOS	Honor scope and effective date
No automatic sequence	Outcomes depend on facts and process

Keep prioritization, safety rating, authority, and operating prohibition separate.

Instructional figure 17. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Saying “65 means you cannot dispatch” without an applicable legal prohibition.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to classify a fictional warning, investigation notice, and OOS order. It must quote no invented order and leave formal legal interpretation to the responsible reviewer.

Try it

Use the threshold reference to compare general and HM criteria, then explain why the table alone doesn't decide whether a particular carrier may operate.

Think it through

Are you looking at a prioritization signal, a rating, or an actual order?

Check your understanding

1. Does an 80 threshold mean the category matters less?

2. Is every intervention an operating prohibition?

Take this with you

Recognize agency attention without inventing an enforcement outcome.

Sources: F02, F06, F07. See source ledger for verification status.

10.02 | Ratings, new entrants, and legal stops

A safety rating is a separate federal determination. Satisfactory, Conditional, and Unsatisfactory have meanings under the safety-fitness rules. None or Not Rated means no rating has been assigned; it isn't a fourth favorable rating.

A Conditional rating isn't, by that label alone, the same as an effective federal operating prohibition. It still deserves careful review under applicable law and company policy. A final Unsatisfactory rating has operating consequences under Part 385. Verify whether a rating is proposed or final, its effective date, the operation involved, and any applicable order. Don't decide from an old screenshot or treat a proposed rating as already final.

An active applicable OOS order must be honored. Its scope may concern a vehicle, driver, or carrier operation. A replacement truck doesn't cure a carrier-wide prohibition. A historical roadside OOS finding doesn't by itself establish that the carrier remains prohibited today. Read the current official record and the actual notice when available.

New entrants have their own monitoring and audit process. FMCSA’s general property-carrier guidance describes an 18-month monitoring period and a safety audit within the first 12 months of operations. This book focuses on property freight; passenger and specialized operations can have different timing and requirements. The audit checks basic safety-management controls. A new entrant’s lack of a federal rating isn't evidence that it passed a full safety-fitness review.

Cedar Valley therefore needs a readiness review and attention to its actual new-entrant status. Don't say “new means unsafe,” and don't say “registered means audited and approved.” Ask what records and controls are in place, whether notices have been received, and what current obligations apply. Distinguish lawful operation from your company’s decision to accept a particular assignment.

17 Intervention is not automatic shutdown

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Observed information	Interpretation
Elevated applicable BASIC percentile	May support intervention prioritization
Warning / investigation	Read actual notice and required action
Final effective prohibition / OOS	Honor scope and effective date
No automatic sequence	Outcomes depend on facts and process

Keep prioritization, safety rating, authority, and operating prohibition separate.

Instructional figure 17. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating Conditional as automatic shutdown or Not Rated as Satisfactory.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to preserve the exact rating/status wording and effective dates in a fictional memo. A lookup summary is not a legal opinion or proof that a notice was fully reviewed.

Try it

Write separate fields for registration, authority, safety rating, new-entrant status, and operating prohibition. Explain why one “status” box is insufficient.

Think it through

Could the scope or effective date change the action required today?

Check your understanding

1. Is a proposed Unsatisfactory rating necessarily already a final effective prohibition?

2. Does a new entrant’s registration prove all audits are complete?

Take this with you

Read the official status precisely, including scope and dates.

Sources: F08, F23, F28. See source ledger for verification status.

10.03 | Responding to FMCSA contact

An official notice arrives. The first useful action is to preserve it and establish what it requires. Ignoring it, guessing at a deadline, or making unsupported promises makes the situation harder.

Confirm the sender through an independently established official channel if authenticity is uncertain. Retain the original notice, attachments, envelope or delivery information where relevant, and date received. Identify the legal entity, requested records, deadline, contact method, and whether the notice contains an effective restriction. Distinguish a request for information from a notice of claim, proposed rating, or OOS order.

Assign a responsible owner and create a worklist. Identify where each requested record is kept and who can verify it. Preserve originals. Don't rewrite historical logs, backdate repairs, or manufacture missing documents. If a record is missing, describe that fact accurately and obtain appropriate professional advice on the response. Organizing evidence isn't permission to alter it.

If an active prohibition applies, stop the affected operation. A response letter or a pending correction request doesn't automatically lift the order. Follow the actual process for relief or return to operation and verify the result before resuming. Where enforcement or legal consequences are involved, the responsible carrier should obtain qualified advice rather than relying on a classroom example as its case strategy.

For a fictional Pine Ridge records request, the worklist might include inspection reports, matched repairs, maintenance procedures, and evidence of follow-up. Each item needs an owner, due date, and completeness check. Keep the carrier’s corrective work moving, but don't promise the agency will accept it or remove a finding. The decision belongs to the applicable authority.

19 The corrective-action circle

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1	Read the report and verify the facts
2	Investigate cause without assuming motive
3	Repair, coach, or correct qualification controls
4	Preserve proof and verify completion
5	Monitor later evidence and effectiveness
6	Reassess the human decision

Continue operating only where lawful. A calendar does not guarantee score repair.

Instructional figure 19. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Assuming a submitted response or DataQs request suspends an order or deadline.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to organize a fictional notice into requested items and dates. Drafting support is proposed; no message, filing, or legal response is sent automatically.

Try it

Create a response worklist for a mock records request without inventing an agency deadline. Use “from actual notice” where the classroom packet supplies none.

Think it through

Which facts must be preserved exactly rather than paraphrased?

Check your understanding

1. Does filing a correction request automatically lift an OOS order?

2. Should missing records be recreated as though they existed at the time?

Take this with you

Preserve the notice, assign the work, and follow the actual requirements.

Sources: F19, F23, F28. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 10 | Attention versus prohibition

Use: W06

Compare an elevated applicable percentile, Conditional rating, proposed Unsatisfactory rating, and active applicable OOS order.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

11 | Improve the record the right way

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

11.01 | Real improvement is operational

The safest way to improve a safety record is to improve the operation that produces it. A cleaner summary is useful only if the trucks, drivers, schedules, and qualification controls are actually better.

Start with one recurring issue. Pine Ridge’s brake pattern requires correction of affected equipment and investigation of the maintenance process. Ask how defects are reported, how work is prioritized, who verifies completion, and what prevents an unrepaired unit from being assigned. If the problem is a missed inspection step, name that step. If the cause isn't established, keep the investigation open instead of selecting a convenient explanation.

Driving patterns require their own response. Blue Ridge’s repeated following-distance and speed findings may call for coaching and review of dispatch expectations, supervision, and subsequent behavior. Don't substitute a maintenance invoice for a driving response or a training attendance sheet for evidence that repairs were completed.

Use W11 to assign each action to a person and due date. Define completion evidence before calling the action closed. For a repair, that may include a unit-matched work record and appropriate verification. For a process change, it may include the revised procedure, training, and later checks showing it is used. An action can be completed while effectiveness remains under review.

Create a 30/60/90-day plan with meaningful checks. In the first period, address current defects and required gates. In the next, verify the new process is being followed. Later, compare available inspections, internal observations, and remaining gaps. Those are management review intervals, not a promise that SMS ranks or insurance costs will improve on a deadline. Continue only where operation is lawful throughout.

19 The corrective-action circle

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1	Read the report and verify the facts
2	Investigate cause without assuming motive
3	Repair, coach, or correct qualification controls
4	Preserve proof and verify completion
5	Monitor later evidence and effectiveness
6	Reassess the human decision

Continue operating only where lawful. A calendar does not guarantee score repair.

Instructional figure 19. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Closing an action because somebody promised to fix it, or blaming every recurrence on the last driver hired.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to format an action register from fictional evidence. Integrated corrective-action tracking and CSA coaching are proposed and require human verification.

Try it

Create one repair action, one process action, and one effectiveness check for Pine Ridge, each with an owner and proof of completion.

Think it through

What would tell you the action was completed but didn't work?

Check your understanding

1. Is a promised repair completion evidence?

2. Does a 90-day plan guarantee a better percentile?

Take this with you

Fix the condition, improve the process, and check the result.

Sources: F02, F03. See source ledger for verification status.

11.02 | DataQs: correct facts with evidence

Sometimes the record is wrong. A report may be assigned to the wrong carrier, contain an incorrect detail, or need review after an applicable adjudicated citation outcome. DataQs provides a process to request review; it doesn't sell a clean record.

Open https://dataqs.fmcsa.dot.gov/ and read the Help Center’s instructions. Use your own properly authorized account. Identify the specific inspection, crash, or other supported record issue and the appropriate Request for Data Review, or RDR, type. Explain the factual problem precisely. Attach relevant supporting documents and preserve a copy of the submission and request identifier. Follow the current site instructions and monitor the request status.

For a wrong-carrier training example, state the disputed report ID and the identity conflict. Identify evidence that connects the inspected vehicle and operation to the correct carrier. Don't upload unrelated private records. The reviewing state or federal authority evaluates the request; submitting it doesn't prove your claim or immediately change SMS.

An adjudicated citation result may warrant review under the applicable DataQs rules, but a dismissed citation isn't a universal promise that every related inspection entry disappears. Obtain the final disposition and follow the relevant instructions. Keep court outcomes, roadside findings, and agency record updates distinct. If the response requests additional evidence, address that request rather than resubmitting unsupported assertions.

Pine Ridge’s valid brake defects don't become false because the carrier repaired the brakes. Repairs belong in the corrective-action evidence. A factual error belongs in a data-review request. Sometimes both exist in the same case, but they answer different questions. Protect the original record and add the outcome when the authority decides.

19 The corrective-action circle

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Step	Action
1	Read the report and verify the facts
2	Investigate cause without assuming motive
3	Repair, coach, or correct qualification controls
4	Preserve proof and verify completion
5	Monitor later evidence and effectiveness
6	Reassess the human decision

Continue operating only where lawful. A calendar does not guarantee score repair.

Instructional figure 19. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Filing a challenge as though it automatically deletes a valid violation or suspends an operating restriction.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to organize a mock evidence list and distinguish the alleged error from supporting facts. Proposed case tracking must not promise approval or submit a real request without authorization.

Try it

Complete W10 for a fictional wrong-carrier entry. Include the disputed field, evidence, requested correction, and a pending-status note.

Think it through

Is your request about an inaccurate record or an accurate event you wish hadn't happened?

Check your understanding

1. Who decides whether a DataQs request warrants correction?

2. Does repairing a cited defect make the original finding inaccurate?

Take this with you

Challenge specific inaccuracies and preserve the review trail.

Sources: F19. See source ledger for verification status.

11.03 | Crash preventability and the recovery calendar

Golden Plains' truck was reportedly struck while legally stopped. That fact pattern may fit the Crash Preventability Determination Program, or CPDP. Eligibility and a favorable determination are separate steps.

Open FMCSA's CPDP page and compare the actual crash facts with the eligible types and date rules. The program reviewed for this edition covers 21 specified types for crashes on or after December 1, 2024; earlier crashes follow the earlier criteria. The current page also states that crashes older than five years cannot be reviewed. Recheck eligibility before preparing a real request.

The request goes through DataQs with the required police accident report and relevant supporting evidence, such as photographs or video where available. Identify the crash and explain how the evidence supports the selected type. A narrative that the driver was innocent isn't a substitute for the required report. Preserve originals and disclose uncertainties honestly.

If FMCSA determines the crash Not Preventable under CPDP, it is excluded from the SMS Crash Indicator calculation but remains listed. The determination is also noted in PSP. It doesn't automatically change the carrier's federal safety rating. A public crash listing, SMS calculation treatment, PSP annotation, and safety rating are separate record concepts.

Keep the recovery calendar realistic. Data review can take time, and monthly SMS publication has its own cycle. Record submission, response, decision, and the later source check. Don't promise that a change will appear tomorrow or that an insurer will reduce a premium. Meanwhile, address any real operational issues the investigation reveals and continue only where lawful.

18 Crash involvement and preventability

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Stage	Effect
Crash reported	Involvement does not establish fault
Eligible CPDP request	Evidence and required police report submitted
Not Preventable determination	Excluded from Crash Indicator calculation
Record still listed	PSP notation; no automatic safety-rating change

No favorable outcome is promised. Check current eligibility and the actual determination.

Instructional figure 18. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Saying a favorable CPDP result erases the crash or automatically produces a Satisfactory rating.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT for a mock CPDP evidence checklist and date log. Proposed review support cannot determine preventability for FMCSA or promise a processing time.

Try it

Use the Golden Plains narrative to identify a potentially eligible type, missing required evidence, and the exact effect of a favorable determination.

Think it through

Which record would you check later to confirm the determination was reflected correctly?

Check your understanding

1. Does Not Preventable remove the crash listing?

2. Is a police report optional for the CPDP packet described here?

Take this with you

Seek the right determination and describe its limited effect accurately.

Sources: F20, F21. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 11 | Correction and recovery

Use: W10, W11

Prepare a mock wrong-carrier RDR and Golden Plains CPDP evidence list. Add operational actions for Pine Ridge.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

12 | Protect the carrier and the load

THE EVIDENCE CIRCLE

See the record → understand what it proves → identify what is missing → ask a fair question → make a documented human decision → monitor again.

12.01 | Broker capstone: should I tender?

You have a dry-van shipment ready to move. Bayou's representative promises capacity and pushes for an immediate tender. The packet, payee instructions, and identity evidence don't line up. Your task is to make a decision from the evidence, not the urgency.

Open the fictional Bayou case file. Write the shipment scope and identify the conflicting fields. State which legal carrier is established and which remains uncertain. If you cannot establish the operating entity, don't continue the review as though the safety data belongs to the proposed truck. An otherwise favorable record for another business cannot close the identity gap.

Your memo should stop this tender pending reconciliation. This is a transaction control based on unresolved identity, not an invented FMCSA prohibition or public accusation. List the independent sources and contacts needed to verify the carrier, authority, coverage, and payee relationship. Keep any questionable message as evidence without forwarding it broadly or treating it as a proven fraud finding.

Once identity is established, the remaining carrier review still must be completed. Verify the appropriate authority, load-specific coverage, equipment suitability, public safety evidence, and customer requirements. Confirm assignment through the carrier's authorized process. Don't demand protected driver reports as a shortcut to deciding whether the company is legitimate.

The capstone isn't passed by choosing red alone. You need a reason another reviewer can reproduce, a fair statement of uncertainty, and a workable release condition. "I don't trust them" is weaker than "the payee entity differs from the packet and has not been reconciled through an independently verified carrier contact." Good judgment can be firm without becoming an accusation.

12 Green Light / Hold & Verify / Stop

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Decision	Meaning
Green Light	Required checks satisfied; authorized human approval
Hold & Verify	Material uncertainty or concern needs evidence
Stop	Do not proceed with defined move or assignment
Always specify scope	Legal prohibition, qualification gate, or company control

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY DECISION AID - NOT AN FMCSA STATUS OR CERTIFICATION.

Instructional figure 12. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Treating urgency as evidence or equating a transaction stop with a government shutdown.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to draft the memo from the fictional packet, retaining every unknown. Automatic approval and third-party communications are not authorized by this exercise.

Try it

Submit W06 for Bayou with source labels, exact mismatches, disposition, reviewer, timestamp, and evidence required to reopen the tender.

Think it through

Would your memo remain fair if the mismatch later proved to be an administrative error?

Check your understanding

1. Why stop the Bayou tender?

2. Does the packet establish fraud?

Take this with you

A defensible stop identifies the unresolved evidence and the path forward.

Sources: F08, F09. See source ledger for verification status.

12.02 | Carrier capstone: should I hire or assign?

Robert’s file contains six reported employers, four PSP inspection events, two speeding findings, two employer replies, and an MVR still pending. The required full Clearinghouse query is pending in this exercise. What can you decide today?

Separate three questions: what the file shows, what remains legally or operationally required, and whether the employer is ready to make a hiring decision. The job count doesn't establish unsafe driving. The speeding findings deserve a fair, job-related review. The pending query blocks covered safety-sensitive assignment until the applicable requirement is completed and eligibility established.

Use W08 to review the application, licensing and endorsements, medical qualification, road test or permitted equivalent, required inquiries, applicable testing, Clearinghouse, and secure recordkeeping. Mark optional PSP separately from mandatory duties. Distinguish inquiry deadlines from pre-service gates. A stricter company policy can require the MVR and employer review before assignment, but label that policy accurately rather than rewriting the federal timing rules.

Ask Robert about the overlapping employment dates and the driving findings. Record his account and obtain appropriate corroboration. Don't infer that an event carrier was necessarily a separate payroll employer. If covered consumer-report information may cause an adverse decision, follow the applicable disclosure, authorization, review/dispute, and notice procedures. Human review must remain fair and consistent.

Compare Elena. Her fictional file says the required checks are satisfactorily completed and the employer changes are supported by closures and seasonal work. That can support an authorized human hiring decision, subject to the actual job and policy requirements. It doesn't guarantee future performance. Aaron remains on hold for timeline reconciliation. These different outcomes reflect different evidence, not a rule about how many jobs a good driver may have.

15 Qualification is more than a signature

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Gate or task	Check
Application / inquiries	Signed history; required investigation
License / medical / road test	Applicable qualifications and evidence
Optional PSP	Permitted purpose and written authorization
Full Clearinghouse query	Required specific electronic consent and result
Required controlled-substances test	Verified negative or documented lawful exception
Human review	Apply each timing rule; do not assume 30-day grace

Illustrative checklist. Inquiry deadlines and pre-service gates differ.

Instructional figure 15. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Calling Robert approved because the application is signed, or rejected solely because six employers appear.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to list completed, pending, and disputed items from the synthetic file. A proposed assistant can organize evidence; it cannot qualify the driver or replace official checks.

Try it

Submit Robert's W08 and W09 with a pending-qualification decision, a separate no-assignment gate, and the evidence needed for reconsideration.

Think it through

Have you separated an incomplete file from an adverse finding?

Check your understanding

1. Can Robert perform covered safety-sensitive work with the required full query still pending?

2. Does Elena's five-employer history require automatic rejection?

Take this with you

Make the qualification decision from completed requirements and supported facts.

Sources: F15, F17, F18, F26, F27. See source ledger for verification status.

12.03 | Keep the safety circle moving

A well-written approval memo is the beginning of monitoring. The truck will need maintenance again. The driver's records and qualifications will change. Government data will refresh. Your process must notice meaningful changes and respond.

Use the same circle each time: see the record, understand what it proves, identify what is missing, ask a fair question, make a documented human decision, and monitor again. The circle keeps you from treating a warning as a verdict or an old approval as permanent permission.

Build a practical review calendar. Check material current status before a tender under your process. Review SMS when new monthly data is available and retain the source snapshot date. Continue required driver inquiries, annual reviews, query duties, qualification tracking, equipment inspections, and maintenance. Escalate a serious new defect or effective prohibition immediately rather than waiting for the next scheduled review.

For Pine Ridge, the first 30 days might focus on verifying repairs and establishing clear defect-release controls. By 60 days, the owner checks whether those controls are actually used. By 90 days, the team reviews subsequent evidence and unresolved patterns. These are fictional management milestones, not federal promises about a score. If the evidence doesn't improve, revise the action rather than declaring success because a date passed.

End each review with an owner, due date, and next decision. Keep private driver information inside the authorized carrier process. Share only appropriate operational conclusions with people who need them. MT may help organize a future workflow, but the accountable person must still read the evidence, honor restrictions, and approve the action. The purpose is to keep legitimate freight operations safe and viable through better decisions.

20 MT: disclosed capability status

FREIGHT UNIVERSITY / INSTRUCTIONAL DIAGRAM

Status	What this book establishes
Publicly described product functions	Applications, files, dates, and DQF tracking
Handoff-reported lookup	Identity / authority / filings; UI not tested here
Proposed / not verified live	SMS ingestion, private-report interpretation, CSA monitoring
Demonstrations only	All fictional MT prompts and responses
Human responsibility	Official checks, access rules, and approval remain

Product claims are not independent production tests. Providers still run MVR/Clearinghouse checks.

Instructional figure 20. Original teaching graphic; not an official screen.

Mistake to avoid

Letting a calendar reminder substitute for reviewing evidence or sending private reports to everyone on a load.

MT / AOS application

DEMONSTRATION ONLY: Ask MT to summarize changes between fictional monthly packets and draft a review list. Continuous CSA monitoring and automatic notifications are proposed; sending any communication requires authorization.

Try it

Complete W11 and W12 with a 30/60/90-day Pine Ridge plan, immediate escalation triggers, and a named human reviewer.

Think it through

Who will notice if an action is overdue, and what will that person do?

Check your understanding

1. Does a monthly review excuse ignoring today’s active prohibition?

2. What is the final output of the review circle?

Take this with you

Keep checking the operation that produces the record.

Sources: F01, F02, F15, F17. See source ledger for verification status.

Field lab 12 | Final review circle

Use: W06, W08, W11, W12

Submit Bayou tender decision, Robert qualification decision, and Pine Ridge 30/60/90-day plan.

Your submission

Record the sources and dates, separate facts from unknowns, show any arithmetic, and write the next human action. Complete the relevant companion worksheet before checking the answer key.

Review criteria

A sound answer uses the correct role, correct record, correct denominator, fair interpretation, and a decision with scope and follow-up. A confident unsupported answer does not pass. Answer guidance appears in the back of this book.

Case desk: four investigations

Investigation A: Pine Ridge and Delta

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL

You are reviewing two prospective carrier relationships on the fictional snapshot date of September 30, 2026. Pine Ridge has four tractors; its inspection and violation files are supplied. Delta's file supplies twenty driver inspections. No repair evidence, current authority confirmation, or load-specific insurer confirmation is supplied.

Your assignment

Calculate both Pine Ridge rates and Delta's driver rate. Identify repeated themes, unavailable categories, and three evidence requests. Write a preliminary decision without claiming a legal ban from historical events alone.

Use the separate case files and worksheets. No case contains a real private driver report or an official carrier rating.

Investigation B: Blue Ridge and Cedar Valley

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL

Blue Ridge has three trucks and a new driver in March. Its file contains April, June, and August events, but not all inspections. Cedar Valley has one truck and zero vehicle inspections in the sample. No current load packet is supplied.

Your assignment

Explain why no full Blue Ridge OOS rate or private percentile can be calculated. Contrast repeat events with absent observations. Draft one operational action and one readiness inquiry for each.

Use the separate case files and worksheets. No case contains a real private driver report or an official carrier rating.

Investigation C: Robert, Elena, Aaron, and Travis

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL

You act for the authorized hiring carrier. Robert's MVR and full query are pending, and only two employer replies are received. Elena's required checks are satisfactorily complete in the simulation. Aaron's reported employer and one event carrier differ. Travis owns a tractor and operates under Pine Ridge.

Your assignment

Complete a reported-versus-verified timeline. Identify pending pre-service gates. Explain fair follow-up and the operating carrier's responsibility. Do not invent a private result.

Use the separate case files and worksheets. No case contains a real private driver report or an official carrier rating.

Investigation D: Bayou and Golden Plains

TRAINING SIMULATION - FICTIONAL

Bayou’s identity file contains conflicting entities and urgency. Golden Plains has a reported rear-strike event but no supplied police report or CPDP decision.

Your assignment

Write separate decisions. Identify independent verification sources for Bayou and missing CPDP evidence for Golden Plains. Explain what a favorable preventability result would and would not change.

Use the separate case files and worksheets. No case contains a real private driver report or an official carrier rating.

Final practical and knowledge check

Practical exam

Submit the Bayou tender memo, Robert qualification review, and Pine Ridge 30/60/90-day plan. Include source dates, evidence, unknowns, role boundaries, disposition, reviewer, timestamp, and next review. Use the four investigations to support your reasoning.

Scoring rubric: 100 points

Identity and authorization - 20 points

20: correct, evidence-linked, complete for the packet. 10: mostly correct but a material gap remains. 0: missing or materially wrong. Partial scores between these anchors may be used with written feedback.

Public safety and OOS interpretation - 20 points

20: correct, evidence-linked, complete for the packet. 10: mostly correct but a material gap remains. 0: missing or materially wrong. Partial scores between these anchors may be used with written feedback.

Seven-BASIC evidence and missing data - 20 points

20: correct, evidence-linked, complete for the packet. 10: mostly correct but a material gap remains. 0: missing or materially wrong. Partial scores between these anchors may be used with written feedback.

Driver privacy and qualifications - 20 points

20: correct, evidence-linked, complete for the packet. 10: mostly correct but a material gap remains. 0: missing or materially wrong. Partial scores between these anchors may be used with written feedback.

Decision, corrective action, and review - 20 points

20: correct, evidence-linked, complete for the packet. 10: mostly correct but a material gap remains. 0: missing or materially wrong. Partial scores between these anchors may be used with written feedback.

Passing recommendation

85/100 plus correct handling of legal stops and protected-record access. An answer that permits work under a current applicable prohibition, permits covered work with a required pre-service gate incomplete, or treats private reports as automatic broker entitlement must be corrected and reassessed regardless of the average. This is a course rule, not a federal licensing examination.

20-question knowledge check

1. A company's vehicle OOS is 3 out of 12 eligible vehicle inspections. What percentage is that?

2. Is that 25th SMS percentile?

3. A carrier has six BASICs without public warnings and repeated maintenance OOS records. Are the six enough?

4. Are the public property-carrier SMS percentile rankings visible?

5. Where does an outsider download the carrier's publicly available SMS inspection/violation data?

6. Does that download contain all infractions for the company's lifetime?

7. What federal site gives a concise carrier snapshot with inspection and OOS summary?

8. What federal site checks a carrier's specific interstate authority and insurance filings?

9. Does an FMCSA 'None/Not Rated' safety rating mean the carrier was rated Satisfactory?

10. Does crossing a 65 BASIC percentile automatically terminate operating authority?

11. Are one brake and one tire violation recorded on the same inspection two inspections?

12. Can a broker demand a driver's Clearinghouse record simply because it is onboarding the carrier?

13. Is PSP mandatory for every motor carrier hire?

14. What are PSP windows?

15. Does PSP list all employment separations and reasons?

16. Where does the motor carrier obtain driver MVRs?

17. Do six reported jobs prove a driver is unsafe?

18. Is an AOS e-signature enough for a full preemployment Clearinghouse query?

19. If a crash is ruled Not Preventable under CPDP, does it disappear from records and automatically improve the official safety rating?

20. What is the best output from an MT carrier review?

Desk references

Current intervention thresholds

Current seven-BASIC baseline. General / placardable HM / passenger. All three columns checked against the SMS Help Center on October 30, 2026. Confirm applicable carrier criteria and methodology before operational interpretation.

BASIC	General	HM	Passenger
Unsafe Driving	65	60	50
Crash Indicator	65	60	50
HOS Compliance	65	60	50
Vehicle Maintenance	80	75	65
Controlled Substances/Alcohol	80	75	65
Driver Fitness	80	75	65
HM Compliance	80	80	80

Thresholds prioritize intervention. They are not an automatic operating ban or an approval table. [F06, F07]

Read the worksheet fields

W01 | Carrier identification

Reviewer / lookup timestamp / time zone; USDOT or MC input type / exact identifier; Legal name / DBA / physical address match; Registration / MCS-150 date / reported fleet figures; Authority type / status / effective date / source; Insurance filings / insurer confirmation / date / load suitability; Equipment / commodity / route / unresolved mismatch.

W02 | SAFER interpretation

Source URL / lookup time / data period; Vehicle inspections / vehicle OOS inspections; Vehicle OOS divided by eligible vehicle inspections x 100; Driver inspections / driver OOS inspections / driver rate; Displayed national average / date / comparison limits; Crash counts / rating exactly as shown / date; Small sample / missing data / questions.

W03 | Seven-BASIC evidence

Category / source / snapshot date; Public measure if visible; never infer private percentile; Relevant inspection count / violation themes / recency; Hidden or missing data / insufficient observations; Follow-up question / carrier response / verification; Reviewer / disposition / next review.

W04 | SMS export audit

Source URL / filename / scope / data-through date; Original retained / working-copy name; Unique inspection count / eligible vehicle and driver totals; Violation row count / separate OOS inspection counts; Repeated theme / exact report IDs / dates; Conflicts / missing fields / linked detail / challenge reference; Observed fact / inference / follow-up.

W05 | Carrier interview

Carrier / interviewer / date / source event IDs; What happened and which unit was affected?; What repair or corrective action was completed, by whom, and when?; What evidence independently connects action to this finding?; What changed to prevent recurrence?; Any current investigation or applicable order? Verify scope and dates.; Unresolved questions / next evidence request / review date.

W06 | Human decision memo

Carrier or driver / load or assignment / reviewer / timestamp; Identity / authority / coverage / source dates; Observed safety evidence / correct numeric denominators; Unknowns / protected data limits / carrier or driver response; Legal requirement versus company policy / evidence reviewed; Green Light, Hold & Verify, or Stop / exact scope / reason; Evidence required to change decision / owner / next review date.

W07 | Driver application timeline

Authorized employer / reviewer / application date; Reported employer / start and end dates / role; CDL CMV work / applicable 3-year and 10-year history; Gap or overlap / neutral question; Applicant explanation / inquiry and response dates; Corroborating evidence / verified versus reported; Outstanding follow-up / responsible person / deadline.

W08 | Driver screening checklist

Authorized employer / reviewer / intended operation; Signed application / required employer inquiries / deadlines; States and MVR dates / requested, received, reviewed; CDL class / endorsements / restrictions / medical qualification; Road test or permitted equivalent / evidence; Optional PSP / permitted purpose / required written authorization; Applicable full Clearinghouse query / specific consent / completed result; Required testing / verified negative or documented lawful exception; Pre-service gates complete? / annual review and query due dates; Secure records / limited access / human authorization date.

W09 | Discrepancy and fairness log

Reported fact / independent record / source dates; Exact discrepancy / possible legitimate explanations; Neutral question / driver response / date; Corroborating evidence / unresolved issue; Consistent job-related criterion / policy; Applicable consumer-report disclosure, consent, pre-adverse and final notice steps; Authorized human decision / rationale / follow-up.

W10 | DataQs evidence log

Authorized requester / report ID / date / record type; Specific field alleged inaccurate / proposed correction; Supporting evidence / source / attachment list; RDR submission date / identifier / current status; Authority response / further evidence / due date; Outcome / later source verification / no promised removal.

W11 | Corrective action and 30/60/90-day plan

Issue / event IDs / verified cause or investigation pending; Immediate restriction or repair / responsible person; Process or coaching action / due date; Completion proof / reviewer / date; Effectiveness check / later evidence / unresolved recurrence; 30-day / 60-day / 90-day review milestones; Next decision / no guaranteed score or premium outcome.

W12 | Monthly change log

Carrier / reviewer / current and prior snapshot dates; Authority / insurance / identity change and source; New, corrected, or aged-out available events; Repeat themes / sample sizes / missing or private data; Corrective-action progress / effectiveness evidence; Human decision update / immediate escalation triggers; Next review / authorized recipients of any communication.

Answer keys and feedback

01.01 / 1. What does a USDOT number identify?

A registered entity; it is not by itself proof of the right operating authority, insurance, or safety.

01.01 / 2. Does a broker’s carrier packet authorize a private driver query?

No. A packet doesn't supply a lawful driver-report role or replace required consent.

01.02 / 1. Does Not Rated mean Satisfactory?

No. It means no federal safety rating was assigned.

01.02 / 2. Do zero recorded inspections prove Cedar Valley is safe?

No. They provide no roadside inspection sample for that period; seek other relevant evidence.

01.03 / 1. Are these colors FMCSA ratings?

No. They are a local teaching decision aid.

01.03 / 2. Is a historical OOS event always a current operating ban?

No. Check the affected unit, correction evidence, order scope, and present status.

02.01 / 1. Is SAFER a violation-by-violation lifetime report?

No. It is a summary with defined record windows and limitations.

02.01 / 2. What should you verify before copying inspection counts?

The carrier identity, number type, source, and record period.

02.02 / 1. Is an authority application the same as granted effective authority?

No. Read the actual status and dates.

02.02 / 2. Can a broker-only entity be treated as the hauling carrier?

No. Confirm the operating motor carrier and its applicable authority.

02.03 / 1. Who can obtain a CSP directly through the carrier Portal process?

An authorized company official with the appropriate Portal access.

02.03 / 2. Is a carrier-shared percentile publicly verified?

No. Label its private, carrier-provided source and verify appropriately.

03.01 / 1. Is CSA one official carrier score?

No. Distinguish the program, category measures, comparative percentiles, and federal ratings.

03.01 / 2. Can six quiet categories cancel repeated brake defects?

No. Investigate the serious pattern on its own evidence.

03.02 / 1. Does Driver Fitness mean physical exercise?

No. Here it concerns driver qualification requirements.

03.02 / 2. Does a log violation alone prove dispatch coercion?

No. Investigate the circumstances and evidence before assigning cause.

03.03 / 1. Does a reported crash establish the carrier caused it?

No. Review the facts and any applicable official determination.

03.03 / 2. Can a public BASIC reveal a complete private drug-test history?

No. Protected testing and query records follow separate access rules.

04.01 / 1. What is Pine Ridge's vehicle OOS rate?

25% for the fictional sample: two vehicle OOS inspections divided by eight eligible vehicle inspections.

04.01 / 2. Is zero driver OOS proof of zero unsafe-driving violations?

No. Some violations do not result in driver OOS.

04.02 / 1. What information is needed beyond a few violations to determine a real percentile?

The applicable methodology, qualifying measure and data, comparison population, and snapshot.

04.02 / 2. Does crossing a threshold automatically prohibit operation?

No. Prioritization and an effective legal prohibition are separate.

04.03 / 1. Do all BASICs use the same exposure denominator?

No. Use the current category-specific methodology for exact calculations.

04.03 / 2. Does a driver leaving remove valid earlier carrier events?

No. Historical attribution and applicable record windows remain.

05.01 / 1. Is the lookup date necessarily the data-through date?

No. Preserve both; the source data may be older.

05.01 / 2. Is a hidden property-carrier percentile a sign of a clean record?

No. It is an access/display limitation.

05.02 / 1. Which formats does the SMS Help Center describe?

Excel/XLS and XML; confirm the current available controls when using the site.

05.02 / 2. Can a violation-only subset supply a full OOS denominator?

Not necessarily. Obtain all eligible inspection counts for the same period and type.

05.03 / 1. How many inspections are represented by two violations sharing one valid inspection ID?

One inspection, with two violation findings.

05.03 / 2. Should a disputed valid-looking row be removed from your source copy?

No. Preserve it and document the dispute and any official correction separately.

06.01 / 1. What connects a repair to an inspection finding?

Matching unit, date, cited condition, completed work, and appropriate verification/release evidence.

06.01 / 2. Must a repaired carrier remain on hold forever?

No. Reassess current eligibility, evidence, and policy fairly.

06.02 / 1. Can a carrier have a 0% driver OOS rate and repeated unsafe-driving findings?

Yes. Not every violation results in driver OOS.

06.02 / 2. Does a cluster prove dispatch pressure caused it?

No. It supports investigation, not a concluded cause.

06.03 / 1. Does a new authority with no inspections automatically fail?

No. Evaluate readiness, applicable requirements, and policy with the limits stated.

06.03 / 2. Should an unresolved material identity mismatch be ignored because safety data looks good?

No. The data may describe a different company.

07.01 / 1. Does a broker normally own the hiring carrier’s driver qualification file?

No. The carrier owns its duties; protected records require lawful access.

07.01 / 2. Can customer policy be stricter than the minimum legal operating status?

A company may apply relevant lawful requirements, but label them as policy rather than a federal prohibition.

07.02 / 1. Does dispatching alone authorize private driver queries?

No. A real authorized role, lawful purpose, and required consent still control.

07.02 / 2. What should happen when a delay makes the schedule unworkable?

Reassess lawful timing and communicate changes; don't conceal duty time or pressure unsafe operation.

07.03 / 1. Should a carrier statement be labeled independently verified?

No. Preserve its source and seek appropriate corroboration.

07.03 / 2. Does a monthly review schedule replace immediate response to a legal stop?

No. Respond to the current prohibition or urgent condition immediately.

08.01 / 1. Is an application's employment history independently verified?

No. It is the applicant's report until investigated and corroborated.

08.01 / 2. Does the ten-year requirement cover every job for every applicant?

No. Distinguish the three-year employer history from the additional CDL CMV-employer history under the applicable rule.

08.02 / 1. Where does an MVR originate?

The relevant state licensing agency, directly or through a lawful provider.

08.02 / 2. Does a 30-day inquiry deadline allow covered pre-service gates to be postponed?

No. Apply each requirement's actual timing.

08.03 / 1. Is PSP mandatory for every hire?

No. It is an optional program with access and consent requirements.

08.03 / 2. Does PSP replace the MVR or Clearinghouse?

No. They answer different questions and have separate requirements.

09.01 / 1. Is an application e-signature enough for a full Clearinghouse query?

No. The driver must give the required specific electronic consent through Clearinghouse.

09.01 / 2. Does a completed Clearinghouse query replace pre-employment testing?

No. Apply the separate testing requirement and any properly documented lawful exception.

09.02 / 1. Does owning the truck eliminate driver qualification duties?

No. The applicable operating carrier duties remain.

09.02 / 2. Should a separate carrier use another company's safety record for approval?

No. Review the carrier actually performing the transportation.

09.03 / 1. Is the $100,000 figure a universal startup requirement?

No. It is a fictional scenario assumption.

09.03 / 2. Will replacing the driver erase the carrier's earlier valid events?

No. Applicable historical records remain.

10.01 / 1. Does an 80 threshold mean the category matters less?

No. Thresholds serve the methodology; they are not a ranking of the importance of safety duties.

10.01 / 2. Is every intervention an operating prohibition?

No. Read the actual action, scope, and effective date.

10.02 / 1. Is a proposed Unsatisfactory rating necessarily already a final effective prohibition?

No. Verify the actual procedural status, dates, and applicable rules.

10.02 / 2. Does a new entrant's registration prove all audits are complete?

No. Check the actual monitoring and audit status.

10.03 / 1. Does filing a correction request automatically lift an OOS order?

No. Verify any actual change through the proper process.

10.03 / 2. Should missing records be recreated as though they existed at the time?

No. Preserve facts and obtain appropriate guidance; don't fabricate or backdate evidence.

11.01 / 1. Is a promised repair completion evidence?

No. Obtain and review appropriate proof.

11.01 / 2. Does a 90-day plan guarantee a better percentile?

No. The plan controls actions and review, not an agency ranking or financial outcome.

11.02 / 1. Who decides whether a DataQs request warrants correction?

The responsible reviewing authority, based on the record and evidence.

11.02 / 2. Does repairing a cited defect make the original finding inaccurate?

No. Correction of equipment and correction of data are separate.

11.03 / 1. Does Not Preventable remove the crash listing?

No. The crash remains listed while calculation treatment and PSP notation change as described.

11.03 / 2. Is a police report optional for the CPDP packet described here?

No. The agency requires it with the request.

12.01 / 1. Why stop the Bayou tender?

The operating entity/payee relationship is materially unresolved; the review may concern the wrong company.

12.01 / 2. Does the packet establish fraud?

No. Describe the mismatch and verification need without an unsupported accusation.

12.02 / 1. Can Robert perform covered safety-sensitive work with the required full query still pending?

No. Complete the applicable pre-service gate and establish eligibility first.

12.02 / 2. Does Elena's five-employer history require automatic rejection?

No. Evaluate verified qualifications and relevant evidence fairly.

12.03 / 1. Does a monthly review excuse ignoring today's active prohibition?

No. Immediate material changes require prompt action.

12.03 / 2. What is the final output of the review circle?

A source-backed human decision, follow-up action, and next review, not an AI safety certification.

Field lab feedback

Lab 01: Roles and decisions

A current applicable OOS order stops affected work. Missing repair proof is a hold. Fully verified required checks allow human approval. Identity mismatch stops the tender pending reconciliation. No rating is not a prohibition or approval. Pending required full query blocks covered safety-sensitive work.

Lab 02: Two public sources

Identity must match before interpretation. Preserve lookup and data dates. Authority and coverage are separate from registration and safety. Use 8 vehicle inspections and 10 driver inspections.

Lab 03: Seven evidence drawers

Unsafe Driving; HOS; Vehicle Maintenance; Driver Fitness; Controlled Substances/Alcohol; HM Compliance; Crash Indicator. Public property percentiles unavailable; Crash/HM BASIC details hidden. Hidden is not clean.

Lab 04: Use the denominator

25% vehicle OOS; 10% driver OOS; undefined/no observations; 0% driver OOS. Rates are not percentile rankings. Delta still has five unsafe-driving findings.

Lab 05: Audit the export

10 distinct inspections; 8 vehicle-eligible and 10 driver-eligible; 2 vehicle OOS and 1 driver OOS; 7 violation rows. PR-I01 has brake and tire findings but one OOS inspection.

Lab 06: Patterns and fair questions

Supported facts include repeat brake OOS and five Delta unsafe-driving findings. Possible scheduling, coaching, or maintenance-process issues remain hypotheses. Request matched repairs and evidence of corrective controls; do not assert negligence or coercion.

Lab 07: Carrier memo

Hold pending material repair and readiness evidence, while separately verifying authority/coverage. A current relevant OOS condition stops affected assignment. No blanket permanent rejection or fabricated government rating.

Lab 08: Employment timeline

Reported history is not proof. Ask about overlap, lease, staffing, or omitted employment. Robert remains incomplete; Elena's verified classroom facts permit human consideration. Job count alone is not a safety verdict.

Lab 09: Qualification gates

PSP is optional 5-year crashes/3-year inspections with proper authorization. MVR is state licensing/driving record. Required full query needs specific electronic consent; pending query blocks covered work. Pine Ridge retains applicable duties for leased-on Travis.

Lab 10: Attention versus prohibition

Prioritization is not shutdown. Conditional is not itself an automatic prohibition. Proposed rating requires status/date review. Active applicable OOS must be honored. Preserve scope and actual notice.

Lab 11: Correction and recovery

RDR needs specific alleged error and supporting evidence; no promised deletion. CPDP needs eligible facts and police report. Favorable result changes calculation and PSP notation, not listing or automatic rating. Valid defects require real repairs.

Lab 12: Final review circle

Bayou: stop pending identity reconciliation, not fraud accusation. Robert: pending qualification, no covered assignment with required gate incomplete. Pine Ridge: actions with owners, proof, effectiveness review, and immediate escalation for legal stops.

Investigation feedback

Investigation A: Pine Ridge and Delta

Pine Ridge 25% vehicle / 10% driver; Delta 0% driver OOS with five unsafe-driving findings. Both need material follow-up. Pine Ridge PR-I01 contributes two violation rows and one OOS inspection. Green cannot be established from the supplied packet. Authority and coverage remain separately unverified.

Investigation B: Blue Ridge and Cedar Valley

Blue Ridge file is a subset: four violation rows across three inspections, no full denominator. Driving and equipment causes must be investigated separately. Cedar Valley 0/0 is undefined. Neither is automatically approved or permanently condemned. Ask for Blue Ridge corrective evidence and Cedar Valley qualification/maintenance readiness plus normal status and coverage checks.

Investigation C: Robert, Elena, Aaron, and Travis

Robert: pending, no covered assignment with full query incomplete; do not reject on job count. Elena: may proceed to human decision under policy and job requirements. Aaron: hold for explanation/corroboration, not dishonesty finding. Travis: Pine Ridge retains applicable carrier duties. Explain applicable FCRA steps if a consumer report drives an adverse action.

Investigation D: Bayou and Golden Plains

Stop Bayou tender pending identity reconciliation; no fraud finding established. Golden Plains needs evidence-based review and required police report before an appropriate CPDP request. Crash involvement does not prove fault. Not Preventable affects calculation and PSP notation, while listing remains and rating is separate.

Final knowledge-check answers

1. A company's vehicle OOS is 3 out of 12 eligible vehicle inspections. What percentage is that?

3/12 = 25%.

2. Is that 25th SMS percentile?

No; an OOS inspection percentage and a BASIC percentile are different.

3. A carrier has six BASICs without public warnings and repeated maintenance OOS records. Are the six enough?

No; inspect the single serious category and the limitations of public/private data.

4. Are the public property-carrier SMS percentile rankings visible?

No.

5. Where does an outsider download the carrier's publicly available SMS inspection/violation data?

SMS Motor Carrier Overview ☐ Data Downloads ☐ the applicable category/all available ☐ Excel or XML.

6. Does that download contain all infractions for the company's lifetime?

No, it is governed by SMS scope, time period, reporting and access.

7. What federal site gives a concise carrier snapshot with inspection and OOS summary?

SAFER Company Snapshot.

8. What federal site checks a carrier's specific interstate authority and insurance filings?

Licensing & Insurance.

9. Does an FMCSA 'None/Not Rated' safety rating mean the carrier was rated Satisfactory?

No.

10. Does crossing a 65 BASIC percentile automatically terminate operating authority?

No; it is an intervention prioritization threshold.

11. Are one brake and one tire violation recorded on the same inspection two inspections?

No, two violation rows can belong to one inspection.

12. Can a broker demand a driver's Clearinghouse record simply because it is onboarding the carrier?

No automatic entitlement; that data is protected and subject to authorized-role/query rules.

13. Is PSP mandatory for every motor carrier hire?

No; voluntary program, with restrictions and required written authorization for prospective-employer use.

14. What are PSP windows?

Five years of FMCSA-reported crashes and three years of roadside inspection data.

15. Does PSP list all employment separations and reasons?

No, only carriers associated with covered events, not a full job history.

16. Where does the motor carrier obtain driver MVRs?

Relevant State driver licensing agencies or lawful agents/providers, under applicable requirements.

17. Do six reported jobs prove a driver is unsafe?

No; investigate employment and actual driving history fairly.

18. Is an AOS e-signature enough for a full preemployment Clearinghouse query?

No; specific electronic driver consent is required inside Clearinghouse.

19. If a crash is ruled Not Preventable under CPDP, does it disappear from records and automatically improve the official safety rating?

No; it remains listed, is excluded from Crash Indicator SMS calculation, and PSP is annotated; safety rating is separate.

20. What is the best output from an MT carrier review?

A source-backed summary of observed facts, dates, unknowns, applicable requirements, follow-up questions and a human disposition—not an invented certification.

Glossary

Authority

Permission for the applicable regulated transportation activity; check type, status, and dates.

BASIC

Behavior Analysis and Safety Improvement Category; seven categories in this edition's current baseline.

Carrier

The business operating the commercial vehicle and holding applicable safety responsibilities.

Clearinghouse

Protected federal drug/alcohol query and reporting system for covered drivers and employers.

COI

Certificate of insurance; verify coverage through the proper insurance source.

CPDP

Crash Preventability Determination Program.

CSA

Compliance, Safety, Accountability: the federal safety program.

CSP

Company Safety Profile; distinct from a public SMS export.

Denominator

The eligible total used beneath the fraction; it must match the numerator.

DQF

Driver Qualification File; required qualification records under applicable rules.

ELD

Electronic logging device used for certain driving/duty records.

FCRA

Fair Credit Reporting Act; applicable consumer-report use carries disclosure, consent, and adverse-action duties.

HOS

Hours of Service; applicable driving, duty, and recordkeeping limits.

MCMIS

Motor Carrier Management Information System, an FMCSA source of safety records.

MCS-150

Motor carrier identification report supporting registration information.

Measure

A category-specific SMS value under its methodology; not a percentile.

MVR

Motor Vehicle Record from a state licensing authority or lawful provider.

Numerator

The counted subset above the fraction, such as eligible vehicle OOS inspections.

OOS

Out of service; read whether it applies to a driver, vehicle, or carrier and whether it is current.

Percentile

Relative position within the applicable comparison group.

PSP

Pre-Employment Screening Program; five-year crash and three-year inspection windows.

RDR

Request for Data Review through DataQs.

Safety rating

A federal safety-fitness determination, separate from a BASIC measure or percentile.

SMS

Safety Measurement System used for carrier safety analysis and prioritization.

USDOT number

Federal registration identifier; not the same as an MC docket number.

Sources and verification ledger

Review date: October 30, 2026. Sources are linked in the digital edition. “Checked” means the public text was reviewed; it does not mean an authenticated transaction was completed. Preserved references are not falsely labeled independently verified. Recheck current law, source dates, and actual screen controls before release.

F01 | FMCSA live SMS

https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/

Live text checked; data September 25, 2026; site October 5; next announced update week of November 9.

F02 | SMS Help Center

https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/HelpCenter/

Help Center checked, including XLS/XML download, category guidance, and all general/HM/passenger threshold columns.

F03 | CSA Measures

https://csa.fmcsa.dot.gov/about/measure

Agency measure overview checked; two-year carrier window, monthly updates, and seven categories confirmed.

F04 | FMCSA SMS Methodology resources

https://csa.fmcsa.dot.gov/HelpCenter/Resources.aspx?type=topic

Methodology resource listing checked; exact Appendix A formulas were not used or independently audited.

F05 | FMCSA approved forthcoming changes

https://csa.fmcsa.dot.gov/prioritizationpreview

Preview checked; updated system described as forthcoming.

F06 | SMS threshold example, general

https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/Carrier/3425304/Threshold.aspx

General-carrier thresholds checked.

F07 | SMS threshold example, HM

https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/SMS/Carrier/2516354/Threshold.aspx

Specific example page could not be fetched; all HM/passenger threshold values independently corroborated in F02 Help Center.

F08 | SAFER Company Snapshot

https://safer.fmcsa.dot.gov/CompanySnapshot.aspx

Direct snapshot request returned 403. Source purpose corroborated in F12; full interactive lookup not tested.

F09 | Licensing and Insurance

https://li-public.fmcsa.dot.gov/

Direct L&I request returned 403. Navigation corroborated in F10 official guidance; full interactive lookup not tested.

F10 | FMCSA authority lookup steps

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/faq/how-can-i-check-status-my-operating-authority-mcffmx-number-registration-and or-application-and

Official lookup guidance checked; no authenticated or CAPTCHA-dependent transaction tested.

F11 | FMCSA CSP current access

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/faq/where-can-i-get-copy-my-company-safety-profile

Portal Reports route and FOIA alternative checked.

F12 | FMCSA Company Safety Records

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/safety/company-safety-records

Company Safety Records overview checked, including SAFER scope and current CSP access.

F13 | FMCSA PSP

https://www.psp.fmcsa.dot.gov/home?redirectUrl=FAQ

Direct page returned offline; official indexed PSP FAQ corroborated 5/3-year windows and written authorization. Ordering UI not verified.

F14 | FMCSA Safety Planner — driver hiring

https://csa.fmcsa.dot.gov/SafetyPlanner/MyFiles/SubSections.aspx?ch=23&eta=24303&sec=66&sub=152

Safety Planner source opened; current legal duties checked against F15 Part 391.

F15 | eCFR Part 391

https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-49/subtitle-B/chapter-III/subchapter-B/part-391

Current Part 391 checked; page displayed currency October 28, 2026.

F16 | FMCSA Clearinghouse — queries/consent

https://clearinghouse.fmcsa.dot.gov/Learn/News/Item/query-requirements-plans-CTPAs

Public query guidance checked; dated examples supplemented by current F27 rule.

F17 | Clearinghouse FAQ Employers

https://clearinghouse.fmcsa.dot.gov/FAQ/Topics/Employer

Employer FAQ checked.

F18 | FTC background checks

https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/background-checks-what-employers-need-know

FTC/EEOC employment background-check guidance checked.

F19 | FMCSA DataQs

https://dataqs.fmcsa.dot.gov/HelpCenter/Faqs

DataQs public Help Center checked; no request submitted.

F20 | FMCSA CPDP

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/crash-preventability-determination-program

CPDP eligibility and record effect checked.

F21 | FMCSA CPDP FAQ

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/safety/crash-preventability-determination-program-faqs

CPDP FAQ opened; main eligibility/effects also checked at F20.

F22 | FMCSA owner-operator duty

https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov/regulations/may-motor-carrier-employs-owner-operators-who-have-their-own-operating-authority-issued

Official owner-operator responsibility guidance checked.

F23 | FMCSA New Entrant Safety Audits

https://ai.fmcsa.dot.gov/NewEntrant/SafetyAudits.aspx

New Entrant audit page and official program FAQ checked.

F24 | FMCSA Driver Safety Measurement system

https://csa.fmcsa.dot.gov/HelpCenter/GetFAQsPage

Agency FAQ request returned 403; source retained from supplied baseline. Recheck before release.

F25 | LFS Compliance Pro public feature statement

https://www.logisticalforwardingsolutions.com/software/lfs-compliance-pro

Public product claims checked; no production feature testing.

F26 | 49 CFR 382.301 - Pre-employment testing

https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-49/subtitle-B/chapter-III/subchapter-B/part-382/subpart-C/section-382.301

Current testing rule checked.

F27 | 49 CFR 382.701 - Clearinghouse

https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-49/subtitle-B/chapter-III/subchapter-B/part-382/subpart-G/section-382.701

Current query rule checked.

F28 | 49 CFR 385.13 - Unsatisfactory ratings and prohibition

https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-49/subtitle-B/chapter-III/subchapter-B/part-385/subpart-A/section-385.13

Current prohibition rule checked at canonical subpart URL.

Production and release record

Created for local founder review

36 reading lessons in 12 chapters; 72 lesson checks with feedback; 12 field labs; four cumulative investigations; 20 final questions; 12 fillable worksheet designs; fictional CSV practice data; glossary; source ledger; 20 original editable diagrams; and a typeset cover.

Outstanding production work

The original course specification calls for 55 photographic assets and 20 genuine annotated screen captures. Their individual instructions are preserved in Visual-Manifest.json and Visual-Production-Briefs.txt. They are briefs, not completed images. Authenticated workflows, mobile device testing, narrated audio, human read-aloud review, and learner comprehension/retention testing remain pending. The book does not claim those release gates passed.

Publication boundary

No publication, deployment, database change, MT Brain ingestion, paid report, TTS purchase, live driver query, or outbound communication was performed. The title and release decision remain with the founder. Before publication, revalidate outstanding sources, complete the selected visual production and review, and confirm the final wording and distribution package.